

Utica University

Fall 2025 Faculty & Staff Climate Survey Results Report

Submitted by: Climate Survey Assessment Task Force

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Executive Summary

Increasing concerns about poor morale among faculty and staff at Utica University led to a decision to garner feedback about the work environment and ideas for improving it. The Senior Associate Provost and two members of the Psychology faculty developed the Climate Survey, which was administered to all full-time faculty and staff in October of 2025. The purpose of the survey was to gain an understanding of the level of morale among employees and the extent to which they feel supported at the institution. The survey was sent to 380 employees. Two hundred and fifty (n=250) completed the survey, representing a response rate of 66%. The Climate Survey Task Force analyzed the survey results and presents its findings in this report.

The Faculty & Staff Climate Survey Task Force began meeting in November 2025 and has held regular monthly meetings since then. This task force is comprised of the following staff and faculty who volunteered for this role:

- *Michelle Boucher, Professor of Chemistry*
- *Sherri Cash, Professor of History & Liberal Studies*
- *Marissa Hall, Executive Director of Student Living*
- *Jing-Mao Ho, Assistant Professor of Sociology and Data Science*
- *Meredith Lopata, Director of Annual and Athletic Giving*
- *Kira Maddox, Director of Community, Belonging & Title VI*
- *Kelly Minerva, Associate Professor of English*
- *Gwendolyn Murphy, Assistant Athletic Trainer*
- *Rose Patterson, Director of Instructional Design & Technology*
- *Deborah Pollack, Associate Professor of Psychology*
- *Alicia Reed, Director of Victim Advocacy & Violence Prevention Initiatives*
- *David Rufo, Associate Professor of Childhood Education*
- *Kathleen Savino, Director of Tutoring Services*
- *Kaylee Seddio, Associate Professor of Psychology*
- *Camille Sorbello, Accounting Manager*
- *Colleen Sunderlin, Professor of Occupational Therapy*
- *Cicily Talerico, Assistant Professor of Occupational Therapy*
- *Shanna Van Slyke, Professor of Criminal Justice*
- *Kyle Wilson, Title IX Coordinator*

During the November 21 meeting, it was determined that the leader of the task force would be Meredith Lopata. Kira Maddox was deemed the point person for all communications from this task force.

Key Messages

Factors commonly noted by respondents that appeared to have a high impact on morale included:

- Lack of communication
- Financial instability and its effects regarding salaries and availability of resources
- Perceptions of a lack of respect
- Employees feeling unsupported, devalued, and excluded
- Issues stemming from poor leadership and mismanagement
- Feelings that the campus community is divided and disconnected

Respondents provided a variety of suggestions to improve employee morale. The Faculty & Staff Climate Survey Task Force took these suggestions and the information provided throughout the rest of the survey and developed the following key recommendations.

- Administration should take responsibility for past decisions that have led to the current conditions at Utica University
- Improve communication and transparency from Administration to the campus community through increased transparency and early consultation on major decisions, advanced notice before important meetings/updates, aligning words with actions, maintaining consistent and engaged leadership presence, and supporting data-informed and evidence-based decision-making
- Create safe open opportunities for faculty and staff to share their views and contribute to decision-making and problem-solving
- Develop clear written procedures and guidelines to ensure processes are followed across campus (e.g. evaluation of supervisors, onboarding, investigating instances of prejudice and intolerance, and accountability)
- Create and promote opportunities for professional development across the campus
- Develop a plan for protecting, reinstating, and improving employee compensation and benefits (e.g. TIAA contributions, raises/performance bonuses, flex work)
- Provide clarity on budgeting decisions, such as budget allocation between departments
- Stop cutting jobs and combining positions and begin hiring more qualified people
- Increase recognition of staff and faculty efforts and achievements (e.g. expand kudos program, highlight accomplishments on social media and across school communications)
- Create and improve relationships between departments across campus and build more opportunities for collaboration, innovation, and shared problem-solving
- Allow departments to close for all to attend important campus-wide events
- Create more social gatherings on and off campus
- Promote physical and mental health of employees (e.g. open athletic facilities year-round, create faculty/staff care team to support wellness)
- Continue the work of the Faculty & Staff Climate Survey Task Force through formation of a working group or standing committee to monitor the campus climate, collecting feedback, and ensure continued improvement of the campus environment

Summary of Methods and Findings

Background

Faculty and staff provided input related to campus climate through a survey administered in Fall of 2025. The purpose of the survey was to assess the work environment at the university and determine the extent to which employees feel supported. The survey also asked respondents for suggestions on how to improve morale at the university. The survey was completed by 250 employees for an overall response rate of 66%.

In order to analyze the survey results, Senior Vice Provost Ann Damiano organized a task force of Utica University faculty and staff who had volunteered. After this initial organization, the task force worked independently from the Administration. The Faculty & Staff Climate Survey Task Force first convened in November 2025 to review and analyze the results of the Faculty and Staff Climate Survey that was sent in October 2025. The intended outcomes of the Task Force included conducting a comprehensive analysis of the climate survey data, providing transparency and clear communication, developing actionable evidence-based recommendations, identifying prioritized areas for institutional improvement, and creating a framework for ongoing assessment and accountability.

Key Findings

Overall, faculty and staff survey respondents identified a variety of factors adversely affecting morale at the university to varying degrees. Factors that were commonly noted by respondents and appeared to have a high impact on morale included lack of communication; financial instability and its effects with regard to salaries and availability of resources; perceptions of a lack of respect, employees feeling unsupported, devalued, and excluded; issues stemming from poor leadership and mismanagement; and feelings that the campus community is divided and disconnected.

- **Communication concerns** center around limited transparency in decision-making, inconsistent communication, concerns about leadership credibility, as well as insufficient opportunities for meaningful and inclusive dialogue across the university.
- **Financial instability** impacts focused on concerns about salaries, benefits, workload, and resource availability for faculty and staff to perform their roles and support students at the university.

- **Perceptions of lack of respect** related to reports of disrespect from faculty to other faculty and to staff; reports of bigotry, discrimination, and bullying; being blamed for institution-wide problems; and perceptions of being punished for these problems.
- **Employees feeling unsupported, devalued, and excluded** were described in relation to work going unrecognized, feeling under-appreciated, employees' opinions being solicited and then ignored, and employees not having a safe place to share concerns without fear of retaliation. The survey results showed that most employees feel supported and valued by their departments, but less so by the institution.
- **Issues stemming from poor leadership and management** included lack of written policies and procedures (including inequitable and unclear review processes), lack of mentorship, lack of professional development opportunities, and issues with senior leadership not taking accountability and responsibility for past decisions and lacking an overall strategic plan.
- **Feelings that the campus community is divided and disconnected** related to lack of awareness of who works in which departments, lack of collaboration, innovation, and shared problem-solving, lack of opportunities to socialize, and feelings of not belonging.

Through the survey, respondents provided a variety of suggestions to address these issues that would hopefully positively affect employee morale (reported in detail below). During the Faculty & Staff Climate Survey Review Task Force's analysis of the data they also developed additional suggestions for how to address these issues and improve morale at the university. These are summarized in the [Key Messages](#) section above and expanded on below in the [Recommendations](#) section of the full report.

Methods

The members of the Task Force divided into four sub-committees, each tasked with reviewing a portion of the data from the Climate Survey, including: quantitative faculty, quantitative staff, qualitative faculty, and qualitative staff. Once initial analysis was performed, the two quantitative subgroups and the two qualitative subgroups worked together to look at data across faculty and staff. Finally, all four subgroups reconvened to pull data together across the entire dataset. An overview of the methods for each subgroup used for their analysis is briefly outlined below.

Quantitative Analysis

The quantitative analysis of the Faculty & Staff Climate Survey data utilized a variety of methodologies to examine the data. These included examining descriptive statistics, group comparisons, predictive analyses, path analyses, topic modeling, as well as others. Results from each of these analyses (p-values, correlation coefficients, effect sizes, etc.) were analyzed to inform key conclusions and drive statistical recommendations from the data.

Qualitative Analysis

The qualitative analysis of the Faculty & Staff Climate Survey data utilized thematic analysis to identify themes from the open-ended response questions in the survey. To do this, all the comments were reviewed, and key ideas from each comment were identified. These key ideas were then sorted into themes and subthemes concerning two domains: factors impacting the current climate, and suggestions for improvement. The faculty and staff responses were first examined separately, and then once initial themes were determined, the data was brought together to identify the key themes that emerged across all faculty and staff responses.

Data Integration

Once the quantitative and qualitative analyses were completed, the Faculty & Staff Climate Survey Task Force came back together to review the key findings and themes across the data. From here, the Task Force worked to summarize the data and finalize a list of recommendations for improving morale at Utica University as well as concrete ideas for how these recommendations can be accomplished.

Faculty & Staff Climate Survey Full Report (Fall 2025)

Introduction

Climate Survey Background

Due to concerns about employee morale at Utica University, the Associate Provost and two psychology faculty members developed a Climate Survey in Fall 2025 to better understand faculty and staff perspectives on this topic. Faculty and staff provided input related to the campus climate through this survey that was administered throughout October 2025. The purpose of the survey was to assess the work environment at the university and determine the extent to which employees feel supported. The survey also asked respondents for suggestions on how to improve morale at the university. The survey was sent to 380 employees and completed by 250 for an overall response rate of 66% (completion rate: 70% faculty; 58% staff). Of these 250 employees, there were 108 faculty members and 131 staff who completed the survey. Five individuals who completed the survey selected “other” when asked about their role at the institution.

The Faculty & Staff Climate Survey Task Force

The Faculty & Staff Climate Survey Task Force was first convened in November 2025 to review and analyze the results of the Faculty and Staff Climate Survey that was sent in October 2025.

This Task Force was comprised of members of the Utica University faculty and staff who volunteered for the Task Force, with a total of [19 members](#).

The intended outcomes of the Task Force included the following:

- **Conducting a comprehensive analysis of the climate survey data** through synthesizing survey results and open forum feedback to identify strengths, areas of concern, and emerging themes across faculty and staff experiences.
- **Providing transparency and clear communication** by providing a summary of findings and next steps to the campus community to promote trust, clarity, and shared understanding.
- **Developing actionable, evidence-based recommendations** including clear, practical recommendations for Senior Leadership and the Board of Trustees grounded in survey findings and community input.
- **Identifying prioritized areas for institutional improvement** including short- and long-term focus areas that align with institutional values, strategic goals, and employee wellbeing.

- **Creating a framework for ongoing assessment and accountability** including proposed mechanisms for tracking progress, revisiting climate data, and ensuring continued attention to faculty and staff experiences over time.

Methods

During the first Faculty & Staff Climate Survey Task Force meeting, the Task Force divided into four sub-committees, each tasked with reviewing a portion of the data from the Climate Survey, including: quantitative faculty, quantitative staff, qualitative faculty, and qualitative staff. The methods that these subcommittees used to review the data are outlined below.

Quantitative Analyses

The quantitative analysis of the Faculty & Staff Climate Survey data utilized a variety of methodologies to examine the data. These included examining descriptive statistics, group comparisons, predictive analyses, path analyses, topic modeling, as well as others. Results from each of these analyses (p-values, correlation coefficients, effect sizes, etc.) were analyzed to inform key conclusions and drive statistical recommendations from the data. These descriptive methods analyzed the results from the survey. We include aggregate interpretations using Descriptive Statistics and Group Comparisons; other methodologies employed are described throughout. *Alpha = .05*

The quantitative group identified 5 key factors from the survey questions that drove our analyses, interpretations, and discussions; (1) tangible resources, (2) soft resources, (3) interactions on campus, (4) processes and procedures, and (5) campus leadership.

A number of recommendations have been made through our discussions and interpretations of the survey results.

We provide recommendations that directly come from the **data** under key takeaways:

- These analyses use statistics to mathematically predict which areas measured from the survey are *best predictors in improving overall satisfaction with the environment at Utica University*.

We have also provided a list of **tangible recommendations** in a separate page:

- These come from committee discussions of personal experiences, historical knowledge about the institution, and what has worked or not worked in the past.

Qualitative Analysis

The qualitative analysis of the Faculty & Staff Climate Survey data utilized thematic analysis to identify themes from the open-ended response questions in the survey. To do this, all the

comments were reviewed, and key ideas from each comment were identified. These key ideas were then sorted into themes and subthemes concerning two domains: factors impacting the current climate, and suggestions for improvement. The faculty and staff responses were first examined separately, and then once initial themes were determined, the data was brought together to identify the key themes that emerged across all faculty and staff responses.

Data Integration

Once the quantitative and qualitative analyses were completed, the four subgroups of the Faculty & Staff Climate Survey Task Force came back together to review the findings of each group and review the data across the entire dataset. The Task Force reviewed the key findings of each of the subgroups and worked across the data to draw conclusions about the factors that were having the greatest impact on morale at the university. Additionally, the Task Force reviewed the various recommendations for improving morale that came from the data, the analysis, and Task Force discussions to come up with a final list of recommendations. This list also includes some concrete ideas for how these recommendations can be implemented.

Findings

Quantitative Findings

Faculty Key Takeaways

Overall, **salary, benefits, and soft resources** have the strongest impact on faculty morale, while facilities have a moderate influence. **Professional development satisfaction is below neutral**, particularly for mid-career faculty (5–15 years), suggesting a perception of limited growth opportunities, while long-tenured faculty report higher satisfaction in this area. Across categories, faculty feel **strongly supported and valued by their departments but significantly less so by the institution**, with perceptions of institutional support and recognition declining as years of service increase. This reinforces departments as the primary sites of support, recognition, and problem-solving, while the institution functions as a distant administrative entity. As a result, faculty increasingly orient their professional identities and loyalties toward departments rather than toward the institution as a whole.

Faculty widely report that although roles are clearly defined, **workload is not manageable, resources are insufficient, and stress is high**—especially among mid-career and long-tenured employees. Socially, the campus is viewed as welcoming and colleagues as respectful, and feelings of **belonging and being valued strongly influence morale**. However, satisfaction with the overall work environment, opportunities to voice concerns, institutional communication, and the impact of policies and procedures are rated below neutral, with communication concerns most pronounced among faculty with 16+ years of service.

Largest Variables Contributing to Faculty Morale:

- Salary and Benefits
- Professional Development
- Support, Belonging, and Feeling Valued by Institution
- Manageable Workloads
- Amount of Resources
- Communication

Statistical Recommendations:

Reduce faculty siloing by formally recognizing and, where possible, rewarding cross-department work, such as participation in interdisciplinary projects or programs, cross-unit initiatives, and institution-wide task forces (e.g., campus climate survey analysis).

Create regular, administration-sponsored opportunities for informal cross-unit interaction, designed to complement, not replace, formal governance structures (e.g., Faculty Forums, interdisciplinary/interdepartmental/interschool collaboration and work groups, etc.).

Strongest Variables **Predicting** More Positive Overall Satisfaction Among Faculty:

(Improvements in these specific areas are statistically more likely to improve overall satisfaction on campus.)

- Professional Development Opportunities
- Reductions in Stress
- Feeling Welcomed
- Feeling Valued / Receiving Support from the Institution
- Communication
- Leadership Effectiveness, specifically the President's role

*Full faculty quantitative data analysis can be found in the appendices.**

Staff Key Takeaways

Overall, **salary, benefits, workload, and respect by administrators** have strong impacts on staff morale, while facilities have a low influence. **Professional development satisfaction is low**, particularly for later-career staff (16+ years), suggesting limited perceived growth opportunities, while shorter-employed staff report higher satisfaction in this area. Across categories, staff feel **strongly supported and valued by their departments but much less so by the institution**.

Staff widely report that although roles are clearly defined, with satisfaction increasing the longer employed at the institution, **workload is not manageable, resources are insufficient, and stress is high**; especially among mid-career (5-15 years) and later-career (16+ years) employees.

Socially, the campus is viewed as welcoming and colleagues as respectful, and feelings of **belonging and being valued strongly influencing morale**. However, satisfaction with the overall work environment, opportunities to voice concerns, institutional communication, and the impact of policies and procedures are rated low, with communication concerns most pronounced among staff with 16+ years of service.

Strongest Variables Contributing to Morale:

- Salary and Benefits*
- Respect from Administrators*
- Manageable Workloads*
- Number of Resources*
- Having a Voice to Share Concerns
- Support, Belonging, and Feeling Valued by Institution
- Communication

**These variables were statistically significant in the analyses ($p < .05$).*

Statistical Recommendations:

Strongest Variables **Predicting** More Positive Overall Satisfaction Among Staff:

(Improvements in these specific areas are statistically more likely to improve overall satisfaction on campus.)

- Professional Development Opportunities
- Reductions in Stress
- Feeling Welcomed
- Feeling Valued, and Having a Voice to Express Concerns
- Communication
- Feeling Respected by the Full Administration
- Leadership Effectiveness, specifically the President's role

*Full staff quantitative data analysis can be found in the appendices.**

Faculty & Staff Key Takeaways

What our quantitative data analysis can support with statistical significance:

Across faculty and staff, the findings from predictive analyses, path analysis, and topic modeling point to a shared pattern of organizational strain driven primarily by organization-level conditions, rather than departmental or interpersonal dynamics. Employee dissatisfaction does not stem from isolated complaints, but from the combined effects of limited transparency in decision-making, concerns about leadership credibility, insufficient institutional support, and a gap between organizational expectations and available resources. Most importantly, stress emerges as the central mediating mechanism through which these conditions affect employee mental health and

erode satisfaction: when administrative leadership lacks clarity, responsiveness, and procedural fairness, stress intensifies, contributing to declines in both mental well-being and job satisfaction.

Morale concerns vary by employee group and by type. For faculty, concerns about material rewards are comparatively less consequential for satisfaction, consistent with compensation structures that are standardized and constrained. In contrast, symbolic rewards, such as recognition, respect, and meaningful voice, as well as institutional resources and policies exert a decisive influence on faculty satisfaction, reflecting the centrality of professional autonomy, expertise, and shared governance to academic work. Staff experiences, while distinct, similarly reflect the interaction of material conditions, workload pressures, continuous organizational change, and the adequacy of institutional support and communication, underscoring that morale is shaped by how institutional decisions are implemented in everyday work.

Overall, the findings consistently indicate that leadership effectiveness matters primarily through managerial functions, such as clarity of expectations, coordination of workload, and reduction of uncertainty, which directly shape employee stress and morale through everyday organizational practices. Decisions about workload, timelines, communication, recognition, and who is involved in decision-making determine whether employees experience their work as manageable and meaningful or as overwhelming and undervalued. When the administration's leadership provides clarity, support, and opportunities for participation, employees are better able to collaborate, learn from data, and adapt to change; when these conditions are absent, employee mental wellbeing and satisfaction decline, and organizational capacity erodes.

What our quantitative data analysis cannot support with statistical significance:

Our analysis does not establish a causal direction. In other words, associations should not be interpreted as proof that any single leadership action caused specific outcomes. Nor do the findings attribute responsibility to individual leaders or units. Moreover, our data analysis does not evaluate the effectiveness of specific past administrative decisions. Rather, they capture how decision-making processes and organizational conditions are experienced by employees. Most importantly, our findings do not suggest that all employees share homogeneous experiences or concerns, nor that all organizational challenges stem from leadership practices alone.

Path Analysis

Figure 1: SEM Path Analysis of Employee Satisfaction

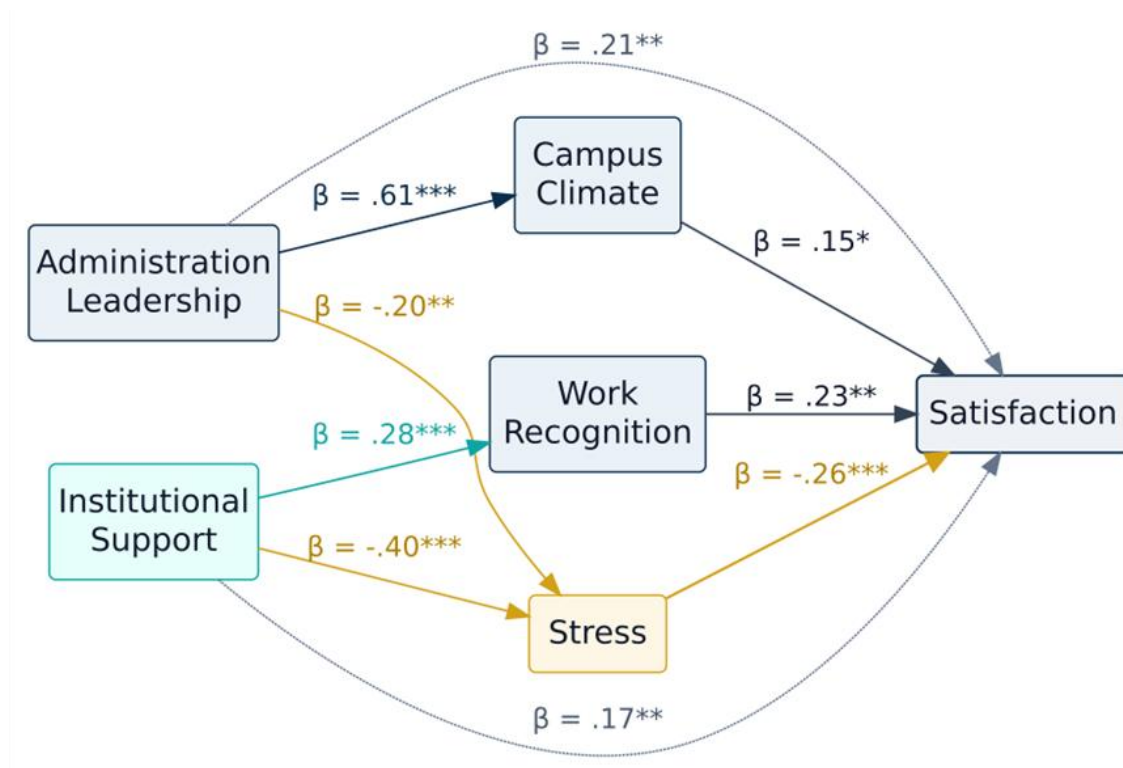


Table 1: Path Analysis of Overall Satisfaction with the Institutional Work Environment

Predictor	Estimate	SE	z	p-value	Type
Role: Staff	0.152***	0.045	3.347	0.000800	Direct
Administration Leadership	0.206**	0.078	2.654	0.008000	Direct
Institutional Support	0.173**	0.056	3.104	0.001900	Direct
Department Support	0.018	0.041	0.450	0.653000	Direct
Campus Climate	0.148*	0.064	2.297	0.021600	Direct
Work Recognition	0.228**	0.075	3.032	0.002400	Direct
Stress	-0.264***	0.064	-4.095	0.000040	Direct
Leadership → Stress	0.052*	0.023	2.274	0.023000	Indirect
Institutional Support → Stress	0.104***	0.031	3.319	0.000900	Indirect
Leadership → Climate	0.09*	0.040	2.243	0.024900	Indirect
Institutional Support → Recognition	0.064*	0.027	2.352	0.018700	Indirect
Total Leadership	0.349***	0.074	4.705	0.000003	Total
Total Institutional	0.342***	0.058	5.846	0.000000	Total

Table 1 and Figure 1 present the results of the path analysis examining predictors of overall satisfaction with the institutional work environment. Role is positively associated with satisfaction, with staff reporting higher levels of job satisfaction than faculty ($\beta = 0.152, p < 0.001$). Perceptions of administrative leadership are directly related to higher satisfaction ($\beta = 0.206, p = 0.008$), and so are institutional support ($\beta = 0.173, p = 0.002$), campus climate ($\beta = 0.148, p = 0.022$), and work recognition ($\beta = 0.228, p = 0.002$). In contrast, departmental support is not significantly related to overall satisfaction ($\beta = 0.018, p = 0.653$). Stress emerges as a strong negative predictor of satisfaction ($\beta = -0.264, p < 0.001$). These findings align with prior research demonstrating the central role of leadership, organizational support, and recognition in shaping employee attitudes and work satisfaction (Podsakoff et al., 2009; Pfeffer, 1998; Spector, 1997).

The model also highlights several indirect effects. Leadership reduces stress, which in turn increases satisfaction ($\beta = 0.052, p = 0.023$). Institutional support similarly decreases stress to indirectly enhance satisfaction ($\beta = 0.104, p < 0.001$). Leadership also positively shapes campus climate ($\beta = 0.090, p = 0.025$), while institutional support enhances perceptions of work recognition ($\beta = 0.064, p = 0.019$), both of which indirectly boost satisfaction. These mediating effects of stress and workplace climate are consistent with research emphasizing the importance of psychosocial and environmental mechanisms linking leadership and organizational support to employee outcomes (Karasek & Theorell, 1990; Glisson & James, 2002).

Considering both direct and indirect pathways, total effects indicate that leadership ($\beta = 0.349, p < 0.001$) and institutional support ($\beta = 0.342, p < 0.001$) have substantial overall influences on employee satisfaction. These results highlight that employee satisfaction is shaped not only by direct perceptions of leadership, support, and recognition, but also indirectly through stress reduction and the enhancement of positive workplace climates, reinforcing findings from both management and sociological perspectives on organizational behavior (Freeman & Medoff, 1984; Rhoades & Eisenberger, 2002; Pfeffer, 1998).

The full Path Analysis findings, including discussion and policy implications, can be found in [Appendix D](#).

Qualitative Findings

In the survey, faculty and staff shared comments regarding the current climate at Utica University and the factors impacting the climate. Separate summaries of the [faculty qualitative findings](#) and

[staff qualitative findings](#) can be found in the appendices. The following sections summarize prominent themes and subthemes that were identified across the faculty and staff responses.

Poor Communication

- Lack of communication between depts, from the top down, to students, to alumni, and out to the public
- Lack of transparency and inconsistent communication
 - Actions don't always appear to align with communicated ideas/plans
 - Rationale for decisions is not always clear
 - Unclear communication about whether there is an overall strategic plan for addressing the university's financial crisis and what the steps of this plan are
 - When input is solicited from faculty and staff, it doesn't appear to be used
- Insufficient opportunities for meaningful and inclusive dialogue
 - Staff don't have a forum like Faculty Senate or AAUP
 - Faculty identified lack of communication to/with the Board of Trustees
 - Opportunities for dialogue are often dominated by a few individuals or are held in spaces that feel unsafe for everyone to share in

Lack of Respect & Feeling Devalued

- Reports of bigotry, discrimination, and bullying
- Reports of being disrespected by faculty (among faculty, and from faculty to staff)
- Feeling unrecognized/under-appreciated
- Staff fear retaliation for sharing concerns/frustrations
- Faculty feel demoralized because their opinions are unsolicited or their potential for making meaningful contributions is ignored
- Faculty feel blamed for institution-wide problems, while staff feel like they are being punished for these problems through furloughs and benefit reductions

Issues with Leadership & Management

- Lack of written policies and procedures
- Lack of on-boarding processes
- Lack of mentorship
- Lack of professional development opportunities

- Lack of leadership training and support for advancement
- Staff reports of inequitable and unclear review processes and no repercussions for people who are not pulling their weight
- Faculty reported that the performance of all employees should be evaluated, especially that of administrators from trustees to deans
 - Some faculty also report a lack of quality in the tenure-review process
- Issues with senior leadership
 - Lack of accountability and taking responsibility for poor decisions and problems
 - Lack of overall strategic plan for university's financial crisis

Division and Alienation

- Lack of awareness of who works in which departments
- No collaboration between colleagues
- Lack of opportunities for faculty, staff, and students to socialize
 - Lack of fun things to do
- Center for Faculty Excellence not being used the way it was intended—as a space for collaboration, innovation, and shared problem-solving
- Feelings of not belonging
 - Lack of cooperation between departments
 - Feeling like athletic venues and grounds are prioritized
 - Feeling of division between faculty and staff

Financial Instability & Lack of Resources

- Significant workload increases as people leave and positions are not filled (usually without an explanation)
- Everyone is being asked to do more with less
- Offices are understaffed
- Staff report that lack of raises, benefit reductions, low starting wages, and worries about job security as diminishing morale and decreasing motivation
 - Reports that Flex Time was initially offered as a cost-saving measure but now it is applied inequitably among departments and is being threatened. Many report that Flex Time is the only “perk” that keeps them working here

- Lack of resources for students
 - Faculty are having to purchase items for students
 - Staff reported lack of classes and program options for students to enroll in

Recommendations

Ideas for how to improve morale at the university were shared on the Faculty & Staff Climate Survey. These ideas were reviewed and analyzed. A summary of this data alone can be found in [Appendix J](#). The Faculty & Staff Climate Survey Review Task Force also contributed some ideas for how to improve the climate based on their review of the climate survey data. These recommendations are combined and summarized here with high level recommendations and specific ways these recommendations may be implemented.

Communication

- Improve communication from Administration to the campus community
 - Frame transparency in decision-making as an operational leadership practice, not solely a communication goal. This includes early consultation before key decisions are finalized, clear articulation of constraints and tradeoffs shaping decisions, and feedback closure explaining how input was considered. The data suggests that clarity and process consistency are particularly relevant to stress reduction.
 - Make the University's Strategic Plan clear
 - Achieve greater transparency and coherence between stated goals and operational actions
 - Provide more advanced notice before important meetings and widely communicate information about these events
 - Aligning words with actions
 - Look and sound confident in decisions and be present and engaged
 - Create an open forum where staff and faculty can speak up
 - Invite more stakeholders to the table
 - Institute regular campus climate check-ins
 - Encourage everyone to always be "selling" UU

Leadership and management

- Administration should take responsibility for past decisions that have led to the current conditions of the university
- Develop clear, written procedures and guidelines to ensure clear processes are followed across campus. Including:

- Evaluations of supervisors
- Onboarding
- Investigating instances of prejudice and intolerance and accountability
- Addressing faculty and staff who do not contribute positively
- Create and promote opportunities for professional development across the campus
 - Have one-pagers or flyers that list out professional development opportunities each month for both faculty and staff (trainings, Nexxus Talks, Faculty Forums, All College Forums, Town Halls)
- Create more opportunities to meet with leadership

Financial instability

- Develop a plan for protecting, reinstating, and improving employee compensation and benefits. Including:
 - TIAA contributions
 - Increased salaries and reinstating raises
 - Performance bonuses
 - Maintaining flex work
 - Discontinue loss of vacation time not used by May 31st/offer unused vacation time payout
 - Add a lower deductible insurance option
- Provide clarity on budgeting between departments
- Stop cutting jobs and combining positions and begin hiring more qualified people
- Other suggested cost saving measures to address financial instability included:
 - Cutting faculty
 - Cutting programs
 - Making cuts more equal between staff and faculty
 - Saving money in other ways (i.e., printing Tangerine in black and white, changing shipping contractors)
 - Redistributing resources to areas of strength
 - Reviewing high-salary positions held long term

Perceptions of a lack of respect

- Create safe, open opportunities for faculty and staff to share their views and contribute to decision making and problem solving
 - Institutionalize respect for expertise, acknowledgment of contributions, and meaningful opportunities for employees to engage in decision processes or to offer feedback based on expertise
 - Bring employees to the table when making decisions and gather input on ways to improve or solve problems
- Address facility issues in all areas of campus in a timely manner
 - Heating and air conditioning should work and when they don't there should be a clear timeline for when the repairs will be completed
 - Office waste baskets should be emptied, and floors should be vacuumed and mopped regularly

Employees feeling unsupported, devalued, and excluded

- Increased recognition of staff and faculty efforts and achievements
 - Find ways to highlight and showcase accomplishments made by all groups (updating websites, utilizing Morning Mentions, utilizing social media, creating a Staff and Faculty "Hall of Fame", etc.)
 - Expand and increase visibility of the Kudos program (e.g. Use the Morning Mention to share out Kudos information or a spotlight, saving some Kudos facts on the website, printing out Kudos--or other such method, like filling out a star or heart-- to put on a board in the hallway)
 - Create process for faculty to share conference presentations and publications and other accomplishments with wider community in addition to annual assessment reports and Morning Mentions
 - Establish "Recognition Committee" (e.g. monthly celebrations for either birthdays or the month you started can share some recognition such as an email or card - doesn't have to be personalized)
 - Implement a reward program from the President to Offices/Departments. Each month the president highlights/celebrates an office/department for the good work

they are doing. A certificate and light snack could be provided, and a photo is taken to be shared in the Morning Mention.

- At another institution, this was called “Rick Rewards,” as the president’s name was Rick.
- Continue with granting employees an early release of 1-3 hours the day before a Holiday break. This could even be considered an “award” if we meet some contingencies set forth prior to the holiday.
- Promote physical and mental health of employees
 - Open athletic facilities year-round
 - Make clear that locker rooms are available and provide loops for laundry
 - Create faculty/staff care team to support wellness
 - Encourage use of PTO and have more time off in general

Feelings that the campus community is divided and disconnected

- Create and improve relationships between departments across campus and build more opportunities for collaboration, innovation, and shared problem-solving
 - Host open houses. Each week/two weeks can have a different department highlighted (in Morning Mention or another format) and have drop-in hour(s) for simple communication of what that department does and who is in it.
 - Offer informational sessions for areas that work with other offices or with faculty – peer to peer teaching. Recognition could be given to both the leaders of these sessions and those who attend these sessions.
 - Create a more formalized method of sharing comings and goings (taking into account HR concerns)
 - Strengthen supports and formal cross-department/school coordination mechanisms by creating institutionally resourced structures that plan, coordinate, and support cross-department/school initiatives, rather than relying on departments to absorb additional work through informal goodwill.
 - Create more gatherings, forums, and focus groups for cross department communication & support
 - Return to the vision of The Center for Faculty Excellence as a space for collaboration, innovation, and shared problem-solving

- Provide mediation support to help departments work through conflicts and improve relationships
- Create more social gatherings on and off campus
 - Trunk or treat
 - Fitness classes
 - School spirit Friday
 - Happy hours
- Allow departments to close for all to attend important campus wide events
- Communicate to faculty and staff together

Future Data Collection and Analysis

- Continue the work of the Faculty & Staff Climate Survey Review Task Force through formation of a working group or standing committee to continue monitoring campus climate, collecting feedback, and ensuring continued improvement of the campus environment
 - Conduct a similar campus climate survey on an annual or regular basis.
- Institutionalize the use of data-driven, evidence-based tools (e.g., campus climate surveys) to support collective inquiry, organizational learning, and continuous improvement.

Appendix A – Factorial Analyses of Variance (ANOVAs)

Faculty ANOVAs

Overview: To better understand key drivers of the faculty experience, the data are organized into five categories: tangible resources, soft resources, interactions on campus, processes and procedures, and campus leadership. This structure allows for a clearer comparison of strengths and areas for improvement within each domain.

Analyses that Follow: factorial ANOVAs were conducted to evaluate the median values compared across different lengths of employment.

Tangible Resources: concrete, institution-provided factors that influence employee satisfaction and morale, including professional development opportunities, salary, benefits, and facilities. These elements represent the practical support structures that enable staff to perform their roles effectively and feel valued by the institution.

Variable	Mean	1-4 Years	5-15 Years	16+ Years
How satisfied are you with the professional development opportunities available at the institution?	2.502	2.542	2.306	2.657
How much does salary impact your morale?	3.928	4.25	3.735	3.8
How much does benefits impact your morale?	3.783	3.958	3.592	3.8
How much does Facilities impact your morale?	3.33	3.083	3.449	3.457

*Variable 1 in the chart above was based on ratings of 1-very dissatisfied ranging to 5-very satisfied while Variables 3-5 in the chart above were based on ratings of 1-very little to 5- a great deal.

Interpretation:

- Salary and benefits have the strongest impact in this category, compared to Facilities. While all three categories scored higher than the median satisfaction, these two categories scored furthest away from the median/neutral point.
- Satisfaction with regards to professional development was below the median/neutral point.
- Satisfaction with regards to facilities appears to have a moderate impact on faculty.
- 1-4 Year Employees: Salary and benefits had the highest level of impact on morale for this group.
- 5-15 Year Employees: Satisfaction with professional development opportunities was the lowest in this group, possibly representing limited growth opportunities.
- 16+ Year Employees: This group reported the highest level of satisfaction with regards to professional development, and close-to-mean scores with regards to salary and benefit impacts.

Soft Resources: the non-financial factors that shape employees' day-to-day experience and ability to be successful in their roles. This category examines perceptions of departmental and

institutional support, role clarity, workload manageability, access to resources, stress levels, and the impact of workload, staffing, and operational resources on morale.

Variable	Mean	1-4 Years	5-15 Years	16+ Years
Other than financial, how would you rate the level of support you receive from your department?	3.964	3.917	4.061	3.914
Other than financial, how would you rate the level of support you receive from the institution?	2.381	2.75	2.449	1.943
My work responsibilities are clearly defined.	3.465	3.333	3.49	3.571
My workload is manageable.	2.95	3.292	2.729	2.829
I have the resources needed to do my job effectively.	2.524	2.792	2.408	2.371
I often feel stressed or overwhelmed at work.	3.794	3.375	4.122	3.886
How much does workload impact your morale?	4.119	4.083	3.959	4.314
How much does staffing levels impact your morale?	4.463	4.333	4.429	4.629
How much does Resources (e.g., systems, software, departmental budget) impact your morale?	4.105	4.208	4.02	4.086

*Variable 1-5 in the chart above was based on ratings of 1-very dissatisfied ranging to 5-very satisfied while Variables 6-9 in the chart above were based on ratings of 1-very little to 5- a great deal.

Interpretation:

- Perceived levels of support from departments scored well above the median/neutral point, while perceived levels of support from the institution scored well below the median/neutral point. Perceived levels of support from the institution appear to decrease based on years of service at the institution.
- While work responsibilities appear to be clearly defined, it appears that faculty feel the workload is not manageable, especially with a lack of resources, leading to feeling stressed or overwhelmed. These identified trends of stress/feeling overwhelmed, work feeling manageable, and lack of resources appear to increase based on years of service at the institution.
- The 5–15-year employees reported the highest level of feeling stress/being overwhelmed and the lowest level of feeling as though their workload is manageable.
- Faculty among all years of service indicated that soft resources impact their morale a great deal, well above the median/neutral point.

Interactions on Campus: The quality of day-to-day experiences and relationships faculty and staff have within the university community. This category examines perceptions of the overall work environment, respect among colleagues, whether individuals feel valued by their department and

the institution, and the extent to which employees feel they have a voice in campus matters. and the impact on feelings of belonging and being valued.

Variable	Mean	1-4 Years	5-15 Years	16+ Years
How would you characterize Utica University for faculty and staff?	3.364	3.500	3.306	3.286
How satisfied are you with the overall work environment at Utica University?	2.42	2.792	2.469	2.000
How well do you feel your contributions are valued by your department?	4.113	4.042	4.327	3.971
How well do you feel your contributions are valued by the institution?	2.541	2.792	2.633	2.20
The institution encourages you to have a voice and express concerns openly.	2.732	2.783	2.612	2.8
The institution provides you with opportunities to share thoughts and feelings about issues of concern.	2.908	3.042	2.939	2.743
I feel respected by my colleagues.	3.954	4.167	3.837	3.857
How much does feelings of belongingness impact your morale?	4.119	4.083	3.959	4.314
How much does feeling valued impact your morale?	4.463	4.333	4.429	4.629

*Variable 1-7 in the chart above was based on ratings of 1-very dissatisfied ranging to 5-very satisfied while Variables 8-9 in the chart above were based on ratings of 1-very little to 5- a great deal.

Interpretations:

- Faculty, regardless of seniority, reported the campus feeling welcoming well above the median while also indicating satisfaction with the work environment was well below the median/neutral point.
- Perceived levels of contributions within one's department scored well above the median/neutral point, while perceived levels of contributions within institution scored well below the median/neutral point. Perceived levels of contributions at the university appear to decrease based on years of service at the institution.
- Faculty who has been employed at the university for less than 4 years reported feeling they had opportunities to share thoughts and feelings. This rating decreased based on seniority.
- Faculty reported feeling respected by their colleagues at a high level above the median/neutral point.
- Faculty reported feelings of belongingness and value impacted their morale a great deal, well above the median/neutral point.

Processes and Procedures: How institutional systems and communication practices shape employees' day-to-day experiences. These measures highlight how clarity, transparency, and consistency in organizational processes contribute to overall workplace satisfaction and trust.

Variable	Mean	1-4 Years	5-15 Years	16+ Years
How effective is the institution's communication regarding important updates and changes?	2.088	2.125	2.224	1.914
How much does Institutional policies and procedures impact your morale?	3.8	4	3.542	3.857

*Variable 1 in the chart above was based on ratings of 1-very dissatisfied ranging to 5-very satisfied while Variables 2 in the chart above were based on ratings of 1-very little to 5- a great deal.

Interpretation:

- Faculty, especially 16+ years, felt effective communication was well below the median/neutral point.
- Faculty reported policies and procedures impacted their morale a great deal.

Campus Leadership: Faculty perceptions of senior leadership and their influence on institutional climate. These measures provide insight into trust, confidence in leadership, and how leadership practices contribute to overall morale and satisfaction.

Variable	Mean	1-4 Years	5-15 Years	16+ Years
I feel respected by the University President.	2.338	2.625	2.362	2.029
I feel respected by the University Provost.	3.03	2.833	3.143	3.114
I feel respected by other senior administrators.	2.887	3.042	3.02	2.6
How effective is the University's President when it comes to addressing challenges the institution is facing?	2.049	2.333	1.898	1.914
How effective is the University's Provost when it comes to addressing challenges the institution is facing?	2.642	2.417	2.796	2.714
To what extent do you feel the University's leadership team cares about your well-being?	1.994	2.25	1.959	1.771

Interpretation:

- Faculty reported feeling respected by the President well below the median/neutral point, with level of respect decreasing by seniority.
- Faculty reported feeling respected by the provost close to the median/neutral point, with a slight level of positive respect from the provost.
- Faculty reported feeling respected by senior leadership well below the median/neutral point, with level of respect decreasing by seniority.

- Faculty reported feelings of effectiveness regarding the President and Provost addressing challenges well below the median/neutral point, with lower levels reported regarding the President.
- The timeframe in which this survey was administered may be relevant to faculty who have been employed at Utica University for less time feeling lower levels of respect, caring for well-being, and addressing challenges due to retrenchment notices (and that process being based on seniority), and proposed program cuts.

Key Takeaways:

Overall, **salary, benefits, and soft resources** have the strongest impact on faculty morale, while facilities have a moderate influence. **Professional development satisfaction is below neutral**, particularly for mid-career faculty (5–15 years), suggesting limited perceived growth opportunities, while long-tenured faculty report higher satisfaction in this area. Across categories, faculty feel **strongly supported and valued by their departments but significantly less so by the institution**, with perceptions of institutional support and recognition declining as years of service increase.

Faculty widely report that although roles are clearly defined, **workload is not manageable, resources are insufficient, and stress is high**—especially among mid-career and long-tenured employees. Socially, the campus is viewed as welcoming and colleagues as respectful, and feelings of **belonging and being valued strongly influence morale**. However, satisfaction with the overall work environment, opportunities to voice concerns, institutional communication, and the impact of policies and procedures are rated below neutral, with communication concerns most pronounced among faculty with 16+ years of service.

Largest Factors Contributing to Morale:

- Salary and Benefits
- Professional Development
- Support, Belonging, and Feeling Valued by Institution
- Manageable Workloads
- Amount of Resources
- Communication

Staff ANOVAs

Overview: To better understand key drivers of the staff experience, the data are organized into five categories: tangible resources, soft resources, interactions on campus, processes and procedures, and campus leadership. This structure allows for a clearer comparison of strengths and areas for improvement within each domain.

Analyses that Follow: Factorial Analyses of Variance (ANOVAs) were conducted for each category to identify differences between and within Staff subgroups based on length of time employed (1-4

years; 5-15 years; 16+ years). Statistical significance of means and corresponding *p*-values are denoted with each table. Effect Sizes (Eta Squared) values are provided to indicate how much of the overall variance of significant variables can be explained by time employed.

Tangible Resources: concrete, institution-provided factors that influence employee satisfaction and morale, including professional development opportunities, salary, benefits, and facilities. These elements represent the practical support structures that enable staff to perform their roles effectively and feel valued by the institution.

Variable	Mean	1-4 Years	5-15 Years	16+ Years
How satisfied are you with the professional development opportunities available at the institution?	2.45	2.51	2.50	2.22
How much does salary impact your morale?**	4.26**	4.16**	4.54**	3.83**
How much does benefits impact your morale?**	4.26**	4.22**	4.50**	3.78**
How much does Facilities impact your morale?	3.13	2.98	3.27	3.13

++Variable 1 in the chart above was based on ratings of 1-very dissatisfied ranging to 5-very satisfied while Variables 3-5 in the chart above were based on ratings of 1-very little to 5- a great deal.

****statistically significant ($p < .01$)**

- Salary (Eta-squared effect size): 8.2%
- Benefits (Eta-squared effect size): 7.3%

Interpretation:

- Salary and benefits have the strongest impact in this category, compared to Facilities. These were the only variables that were statistically significantly related to length of employment
 - Salary contributes slightly more than benefits based on effect sizes
- Satisfaction with regards to professional development was low across the board, with younger staff (1-4 years) indicating higher satisfaction than other groups who have been here longer
- Satisfaction with regards to facilities was lowest among those who have been employed for 1-4 years
- 1-4 Year Employees: lowest satisfaction with facilities, possibly representing quality of office and meeting spaces
- 5-15 Year Employees: Salary and benefits had the highest level of impact on morale for this group.
- 16+ Year Employees: Satisfaction with professional development opportunities was the lowest in this group, possibly representing limited growth opportunities.

Soft Resources: the non-financial factors that shape employees' day-to-day experience and ability to be successful in their roles. This category examines perceptions of departmental and institutional support, role clarity, workload manageability, access to resources, stress levels, and the impact of workload, staffing, and operational resources on morale.

Variable	Mean	1-4 Years	5-15 Years	16+ Years
Other than financial, how would you rate the level of support you receive from your department?	4.08	4.04	4.13	4.09
Other than financial, how would you rate the level of support you receive from the institution?	2.99	2.88	3.14	2.87
My work responsibilities are clearly defined.	3.72	3.67	3.75	3.78
My workload is manageable.*	3.26*	3.69*	3.07*	2.78*
I have the resources needed to do my job effectively.*	2.99*	3.33*	2.91*	2.43*
I often feel stressed or overwhelmed at work.	3.40	3.18	3.54	3.57
How much does workload impact your morale?*	3.76*	3.47*	4.09*	3.61*
How much does staffing levels impact your morale?	4.08	3.92	4.29	3.91
How much does Resources (e.g., systems, software, departmental budget) impact your morale?	3.82	3.73	3.96	3.70

++Variable 1-5 in the chart above was based on ratings of 1-very dissatisfied ranging to 5-very satisfied while Variables 6-9 in the chart above were based on ratings of 1-very little to 5- a great deal.

***statistically significant ($p < .05$)**

- Manageable workload (Eta-squared effect size): 9.2%
- Resources to do job effectively (Eta-squared effect size): 8.8%
- Morale: workload (Eta-squared effect size): 6.6%

Interpretation:

- Perceived levels of support from departments scored well above perceived levels of support from the institution
 - Staff do not feel supported by the institution across the board.
- Stress/feeling overwhelmed increases the longer employed, and lack of resources appear to decrease based on years of service at the institution.
- The 16+ year employees reported the highest level of feeling stress/being overwhelmed and the lowest level of feeling as though their workload is manageable.
 - *Although stress/overwhelm was not significant in the above*
- The 5-15 year employees report that workload affects their morale more than staff employed for other periods of time (this was statistically significant)

- Workload and resources were the most impactful (statistically significant) Soft Resources for staff overall
 - With workload, it is worth noting this appears twice in the results, both in terms of satisfaction of workload AND how their workload impacts morale.

Interactions on Campus: The quality of day-to-day experiences and relationships staff and staff have within the university community. This category examines perceptions of the overall work environment, respect among colleagues, whether individuals feel valued by their department and the institution, and the extent to which employees feel they have a voice in campus matters. and the impact on feelings of belonging and being valued.

Variable	Mean	1-4 Years	5-15 Years	16+ Years
How would you characterize Utica University for faculty and staff?	3.83	3.84	3.77	3.96
How satisfied are you with the overall work environment at Utica University?*	3.27*	3.43*	3.32*	2.78*
How well do you feel your contributions are valued by your department?	4.09	4.00	4.18	4.09
How well do you feel your contributions are valued by the institution?	2.96	2.92	3.09	2.74
The institution encourages you to have a voice and express concerns openly.	3.32	3.18	3.34	3.61
The institution provides you with opportunities to share thoughts and feelings about issues of concern.	3.37	3.25	3.46	3.39
I feel respected by my colleagues.	4.05	4.02	4.05	4.09
How much does feelings of belongingness impact your morale?	3.82	3.98	3.80	3.50
How much does feeling valued impact your morale?	4.28	4.18	4.46	4.04

++Variable 1-7 in the chart above was based on ratings of 1-very dissatisfied ranging to 5-very satisfied while Variables 8-9 in the chart above were based on ratings of 1-very little to 5- a great deal.

***statistically significant ($p < .05$)**

- Satisfaction with overall work environment (Eta-squared effect size): 5.3%

Interpretations:

- Staff, regardless of seniority, generally reported the campus feeling welcoming
- Perceived levels of contributions within one's department scored was higher, compared to perceived levels of contributions within institution. Staff employed 16+ years report lower means compared to others.

- Satisfaction with having a voice to express concerns increases with seniority. This suggests those employed for less time may not feel as open to report issues.
- Staff reported feeling overall satisfaction with the campus environment, although this decreases with seniority.
- Staff reported feelings of belongingness and value impacted their morale a great deal (not statistically significant).

Processes and Procedures: How institutional systems and communication practices shape employees' day-to-day experiences. These measures highlight how clarity, transparency, and consistency in organizational processes contribute to overall workplace satisfaction and trust.

Variable	Mean	1-4 Years	5-15 Years	16+ Years
How effective is the institution's communication regarding important updates and changes?	2.79	2.86	2.79	2.65
How much does Institutional policies and procedures impact your morale?	3.38	3.55	3.43	2.91

++Variable 1 in the chart above was based on ratings of 1-very dissatisfied ranging to 5-very satisfied while Variables 2 in the chart above were based on ratings of 1-very little to 5- a great deal.

No variables were statistically significant ($p > .05$)

Interpretation:

- Staff, especially 16+ years, were generally dissatisfied with effectiveness of communication by the institution. Satisfaction with communication decreases with seniority.
- Staff reported policies and procedures impacted their morale more than communication. Satisfaction with policies and procedures decreases with seniority.
- *Note, none of these were statistically significant.*

Campus Leadership: Staff perceptions of senior leadership and their influence on institutional climate. These measures provide insight into trust, confidence in leadership, and how leadership practices contribute to overall morale and satisfaction.

Variable	Mean	1-4 Years	5-15 Years	16+ Years
I feel respected by the University President.	3.44	3.25	3.68	3.26
I feel respected by the University Provost.*	3.59*	3.29*	3.82*	3.70*
I feel respected by other senior administrators.	3.45	3.34	3.57	3.39
How effective is the University's President when it comes to addressing challenges the institution is facing?	3.13	3.12	3.25	2.83
How effective is the University's Provost when it comes to addressing challenges the institution is facing?	3.33	3.12	3.48	3.41

To what extent do you feel the University's leadership team cares about your well-being?	2.65	2.59	2.70	2.70
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***statistically significant ($p < .05$)**

- Feeling respected by the Provost (Eta-squared effect size): 6.7%

Interpretation:

- Staff report feeling more respected by the Provost than by the President, although means for staff employed for 1-4 years were lower than other lengths of employment.
 - Senior administration may want to make more of an effort with new employees.
 - Staff employed for 5-15 years reported more respect by the President and Provost than other groups. It could be there is more support for mid-career staff.
- Staff reported feeling respected by senior leadership more than by the president.
 - Neither of these variables were statistically significant – suggesting no differences in satisfaction across length of employment.
- Staff reported feelings of effectiveness regarding the President and Provost addressing challenges, with lower levels reported regarding the President.
- The timeframe in which this survey was administered may be relevant to staff who have been employed at Utica University regardless of length of time employed, caring for well-being, and addressing challenges due to furlough notices

Key Takeaways:

- Overall, **salary, benefits, workload, and respect by administrators** have the strongest impact on staff morale, while facilities have a low influence.
- **Professional development satisfaction is low**, particularly for later-career staff (16+ years), suggesting limited perceived growth opportunities, while shorter-employed staff report higher satisfaction in this area.
- Across categories, staff feel **strongly supported and valued by their departments but much less so by the institution**.
- Staff widely report that although roles are clearly defined, with satisfaction increasing the longer employed at the institution, **workload is not manageable, resources are insufficient, and stress is high**—especially among mid-career (5-15 years) and later-career (16+ years) employees.
- Socially, the campus is viewed as welcoming and colleagues as respectful, and feelings of **belonging and being valued strongly influencing morale**.

However, satisfaction with the overall work environment, opportunities to voice concerns, institutional communication, and the impact of policies and procedures are rated low, with communication concerns most pronounced among staff with 16+ years of service.

Largest Factors Contributing to Morale:

- Salary and Benefits*
- Respect from Administrators*
- Manageable Workloads*
- Number of Resources*
- Having a Voice to Share Concerns
- Support, Belonging, and Feeling Valued by Institution
- Communication

*These variables were statistically significant in the above analyses.

Appendix B – Predictive Regression Models

Faculty Predictive Regression Models

Overview: To better understand key drivers of the faculty experience, the data is organized into five categories: tangible resources, soft resources, interactions on campus, processes and procedures, and campus leadership. This structure allows for a clearer comparison of strengths and areas for improvement within each domain.

Description of Analyses: Multiple linear regression analyses were conducted for each of the five (5) categories. These predictive (non-causal) models statistically demonstrate how multiple variables within each of the 5 categories simultaneously influence and predict a single outcome. In this case, we looked at satisfaction with the overall work environment as the outcome ($\alpha = .05$). Standardized coefficients (Beta [b]) and associated p -values are listed for each predictor variable with statistical significance denoted in tables. All full regression models were statistically significant ($p < .001$) and Adjusted R^2 values are provided. Interpretations provide data-driven recommendations for where improvements may be more strongly related to **future** overall satisfaction.

In most of the categories, length of employment (1-4 years; 5-15 years; 16+ years) was not a statistically significant ($p < .05$) predictor of overall future satisfaction, therefore we did not control for this variable other than where specifically indicated.

Tangible Resources: concrete, institution-provided factors that influence employee satisfaction and morale, including professional development opportunities, salary, benefits, and facilities. These elements represent the practical support structures that enable staff to perform their roles effectively and feel valued by the institution.

Variable	Standardized	
	Coefficient b (Beta)	p -value
How satisfied are you with the professional development opportunities available at the institution?	.41	< .001**
How much does salary impact your morale?	-.19	.42
How much does benefits impact your morale?	-.03	.84
How much does Facilities impact your morale?	-.12	.13

*Variable 1 in the chart above was based on ratings of 1-very dissatisfied ranging to 5-very satisfied while Variables 3-5 in the chart above were based on ratings of 1-very little to 5- a great deal.

Adjusted R^2 = 17.2%

We controlled for length of employment (1-4 years; 5-15 years; 16+ years) in this model because it was a statistically significant predictor of overall satisfaction in this model.

Interpretation:

- Professional development was the best predictor of overall satisfaction.
 - Providing more opportunities for growth and development for faculty is likely to improve overall satisfaction.
- This was the only category where length of employment was a statistically significant predictor of overall satisfaction.
 - Faculty who have been here longer (16+ years) tend to have greater dissatisfaction with opportunities for professional development and salary.
- This could be due to more financial instability in recent years where faculty took several pay cuts.

Soft Resources: the non-financial factors that shape employees' day-to-day experience and ability to be successful in their roles. This category examines perceptions of departmental and institutional support, role clarity, workload manageability, access to resources, stress levels, and the impact of workload, staffing, and operational resources on morale.

Variable	Standardized Coefficient (Beta)	p-value
Other than financial, how would you rate the level of support you receive from your department?	.03	.66
Other than financial, how would you rate the level of support you receive from the institution?	.43	<.001**
My work responsibilities are clearly defined.	.05	.55
My workload is manageable.	-.02	.89
I have the resources needed to do my job effectively.	.14	.23
I often feel stressed or overwhelmed at work.	-.33	<.001**
How much does workload impact your morale?	-.14	.16
How much does staffing levels impact your morale?	.10	.29
How much does Resources (e.g., systems, software, departmental budget) impact your morale?	.05	.65

*Variable 1-5 in the chart above was based on ratings of 1-very dissatisfied ranging to 5-very satisfied while Variables 6-9 in the chart above were based on ratings of 1-very little to 5- a great deal.

Adjusted R² = 54.3%

Interpretation:

- Support from the institution and feeling stressed/overwhelmed at work were the best predictors of overall satisfaction.
 - Offering mental health support or stress reduction opportunities could greatly improve overall satisfaction of soft resources.

Interactions on Campus: The quality of day-to-day experiences and relationships faculty and staff have within the university community. This category examines perceptions of the overall work environment, respect among colleagues, whether individuals feel valued by their department and the institution, and the extent to which employees feel they have a voice in campus matters. and the impact on feelings of belonging and being valued.

Variable	Standardized Coefficient b (Beta)	p-value
How would you characterize Utica University for faculty and staff? (level of welcoming)	.20	.03*
How well do you feel your contributions are valued by your department?	-.11	.28
How well do you feel your contributions are valued by the institution?	.41	<.001**
The institution encourages you to have a voice and express concerns openly.	-.01	.92
The institution provides you with opportunities to share thoughts and feelings about issues of concern.	-.02	.90
I feel respected by my colleagues.	.12	.25
How much does feelings of belongingness impact your morale?	-.13	.20
How much does feeling valued impact your morale?	-.18	.06

*Variable 1-7 in the chart above was based on ratings of 1-very dissatisfied ranging to 5-very satisfied while Variables 8-9 in the chart above were based on ratings of 1-very little to 5- a great deal.

Adjusted R² = 43%

Interpretations:

- The extent to which the university is welcoming and how well faculty feel that their contributions are valued by the university were the two best predictors of overall satisfaction.
 - Feeling welcomed may refer to how much faculty feel included and accepted on campus, so continuing to provide spaces for this to take place may improve outcomes.
- Feeling more valued by the institution is also a strong predictor of overall satisfaction.
 - Celebrating faculty accomplishments and showing appreciation for faculty contributions could greatly improve feelings of value which could increase overall satisfaction.

Processes and Procedures: How institutional systems and communication practices shape employees' day-to-day experiences. These measures highlight how clarity, transparency, and consistency in organizational processes contribute to overall workplace satisfaction and trust.

Variable	Standardized Coefficient b (Beta)	p-value
How effective is the institution's communication regarding important updates and changes?	.59	<.001**
How much does Institutional policies and procedures impact your morale?	-.04	.59

*Variable 1 in the chart above was based on ratings of 1-very dissatisfied ranging to 5-very satisfied while Variables 2 in the chart above were based on ratings of 1-very little to 5- a great deal.

Adjusted R² = 35.4%

Interpretation:

- Effectiveness of communication was the best predictor of overall satisfaction.
 - Significantly improving how administration and other offices communicate with faculty could significantly impact overall satisfaction.

Campus Leadership: Employee perceptions of senior leadership and their influence on institutional climate. These measures provide insight into confidence in leadership, and how leadership practices contribute to overall morale and satisfaction.

For this regression analyses, both variables related to effectiveness of the President and Provost in addressing institutional challenges were removed due to multicollinearity. These were both added to a separate model presented below.

Variable	Standardized Coefficient b (Beta)	p-value
I feel respected by the University President.	.39	<.01*
I feel respected by the University Provost.	-.20	.056
I feel respected by other senior administrators.	.22	.04*
To what extent do you feel the University's leadership team cares about your well-being?	.31	.01*

Adjusted R² = 47%

Interpretation:

- Feeling respected by the President and other Senior Administrators, as well as the extent to which the leadership team cares about faculty well-being were the best predictors of overall satisfaction.

- o Respect by the Provost was approaching statistical significance which does suggest this *could* be an important variable, but the President and other Senior Administrators contribute **more** to satisfaction than respect from the Provost.
- Results indicate this overall category and statistical model explains a meaningful amount of satisfaction faculty may experience.

Leadership Effectiveness: Employee perceptions of the effectiveness of both the President and Provost in addressing challenges that face the university. These measures provide insight into how much trust employees have in how effective senior leadership can or will be in addressing challenges.

Variable	Standardized Coefficient b (Beta)	p-value
How effective is the University's President when it comes to addressing challenges the institution is facing?	.56	<.001**
How effective is the University's Provost when it comes to addressing challenges the institution is facing?	.14	.13

Adjusted R² = 41%

Interpretation:

- Perceptions in how effective the President is in addressing campus challenges was the best predictor of overall satisfaction.
 - o Faculty perceive the President's role as most predictive of satisfaction compared to the Provost's role. This may depend on the nature of the challenges, where the President is more responsible for handling financial and overall challenges affecting the university.

Key Takeaways (Adjusted R²)

- Soft Resources: 54%
- Campus Leadership: 47%
- Interactions on Campus: 43%
- Leadership Effectiveness: 41%
- Processes and Procedures: 35%
- Tangible Resources: 17%

Largest Variables Predicting More Positive Overall Satisfaction:

- Professional Development Opportunities
- Leadership Effectiveness, specifically the President's role

- Communication
- Feeling welcomed / accepted
- Feeling valued / receiving support from the institution
- Reductions in stress

Staff Predictive Regression Models

Overview: To better understand key drivers of the staff experience, the data are organized into five categories: tangible resources, soft resources, interactions on campus, processes and procedures, and campus leadership. This structure allows for a clearer comparison of strengths and areas for improvement within each domain.

Description of Analyses: Multiple linear regression analyses were conducted for each of the five (5) categories. These predictive (non-causal) models statistically demonstrate how multiple variables within each of the 5 categories simultaneously influence and predict a single outcome. In this case, we look at satisfaction with the overall work environment as the outcome ($\alpha = .05$). Standardized coefficients (Beta [b]) and associated p -values are listed for each predictor variable with statistical significance denoted in tables. All regression models were statistically significant ($p < .001$) and Adjusted R^2 values are provided. Interpretations provide data-driven recommendations for where improvements may be more strongly related to future overall satisfaction.

In most of the categories, length of employment (1-4 years; 5-15 years; 16+ years) was not a statistically significant ($p < .05$) predictor of overall future satisfaction, therefore we did not control for this variable other than where specifically indicated.

Tangible Resources: concrete, institution-provided factors that influence employee satisfaction and morale, including professional development opportunities, salary, benefits, and facilities. These elements represent the practical support structures that enable staff to perform their roles effectively and feel valued by the institution.

Variable	Standardized Coefficient b (Beta)	p -value
How satisfied are you with the professional development opportunities available at the institution?**	.42	<.001**
How much does salary impact your morale?	.01	.95
How much does benefits impact your morale?	.03	.81
How much does Facilities impact your morale?	.02	.85

*Variable 1 in the chart above was based on ratings of 1-very dissatisfied ranging to 5-very satisfied while Variables 3-5 in the chart above were based on ratings of 1-very little to 5- a great deal.

Adjusted $R^2 = 15\%$

Interpretation:

- Professional development opportunities was the best predictor of overall satisfaction.
 - Providing more opportunities for growth and development for staff are likely to improve overall satisfaction.

Soft Resources: the non-financial factors that shape employees' day-to-day experience and ability to be successful in their roles. This category examines perceptions of departmental and institutional support, role clarity, workload manageability, access to resources, stress levels, and the impact of workload, staffing, and operational resources on morale.

Variable	Standardized Coefficient b (Beta)	p-value
Other than financial, how would you rate the level of support you receive from your department?	.04	.62
Other than financial, how would you rate the level of support you receive from the institution?**	.38	<.001**
My work responsibilities are clearly defined.	.16	.08
My workload is manageable.	.13	.22
I have the resources needed to do my job effectively.	.04	.66
I often feel stressed or overwhelmed at work.*	-.24	<.01*
How much does workload impact your morale?	.05	.61
How much does staffing levels impact your morale?	.12	.18
How much does Resources (e.g., systems, software, departmental budget) impact your morale?	-.002	.98

*Variable 1-5 in the chart above was based on ratings of 1-very dissatisfied ranging to 5-very satisfied while Variables 6-9 in the chart above were based on ratings of 1-very little to 5- a great deal.

Adjusted R² = 40%

Interpretation:

- Support from the institution and feeling stressed/overwhelmed at work were the best predictors of overall satisfaction.
 - Offering mental health support or stress reduction opportunities could greatly improve overall satisfaction of soft resources.

Interactions on Campus: The quality of day-to-day experiences and relationships faculty and staff have within the university community. This category examines perceptions of the overall work environment, respect among colleagues, whether individuals feel valued by their department and the institution, and the extent to which employees feel they have a voice in campus matters. and the impact on feelings of belonging and being valued.

Variable	Standardized Coefficient b (Beta)	p-value
How would you characterize Utica University for faculty and staff? (level of welcoming)**	.25	<.01**
How well do you feel your contributions are valued by your department?	.07	.45
How well do you feel your contributions are valued by the institution?*	.22	.01*
The institution encourages you to have a voice and express concerns openly.	-.19	.13
The institution provides you with opportunities to share thoughts and feelings about issues of concern.*	.38	<.01*
I feel respected by my colleagues.	.03	.74
How much does feelings of belongingness impact your morale?	.00	.99
How much does feeling valued impact your morale?	.08	.40

*Variable 1-7 in the chart above was based on ratings of 1-very dissatisfied ranging to 5-very satisfied while Variables 8-9 in the chart above were based on ratings of 1-very little to 5- a great deal.

Adjusted R² = 36%

Interpretations:

- The extent to which the university is welcoming and how well staff feel that their contributions are valued by the institution were the two best predictors of overall satisfaction.
 - Feeling welcomed may refer to how much staff feel included and accepted on campus, so continuing to provide spaces for this to take place may improve outcomes.
- Feeling more valued by the institution is also a strong predictor of overall satisfaction.
 - Celebrating staff accomplishments and showing appreciation for staff contributions could greatly improve feelings of value which could increase overall satisfaction.

Processes and Procedures: How institutional systems and communication practices shape employees' day-to-day experiences. These measures highlight how clarity, transparency, and consistency in organizational processes contribute to overall workplace satisfaction and trust.

Variable	Standardized Coefficient b (Beta)	p-value
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How effective is the institution's communication regarding important updates and changes?***	.41	<.001**
How much does Institutional policies and procedures impact your morale?	.10	.22

*Variable 1 in the chart above was based on ratings of 1-very dissatisfied ranging to 5-very satisfied while Variables 2 in the chart above were based on ratings of 1-very little to 5- a great deal.

Adjusted R² = 15%

Interpretation:

- Effectiveness of communication was the best predictor of overall satisfaction.
 - Significantly improving how administration and other offices communicate with staff could significantly impact overall satisfaction.

Campus Leadership: Employee perceptions of senior leadership and their influence on institutional climate. These measures provide insight into confidence in leadership, and how leadership practices contribute to overall morale and satisfaction.

For this regression analyses, both variables related to effectiveness of the President and Provost in addressing institutional challenges were removed due to multicollinearity. These were both added to a separate model presented below.

Variable	Standardized Coefficient b (Beta)	p-value
I feel respected by the University President.	.19	.03*
I feel respected by the University Provost.	-.23	<.01*
I feel respected by other senior administrators.	.20	.03*
To what extent do you feel the University's leadership team cares about your well-being?	.40	<.001**

Adjusted R² = 30%

We controlled for length of employment (1-4 years; 5-15 years; 16+ years) in this model because it was a statistically significant predictor of overall satisfaction in this model.

Interpretation:

- Feeling respected by the President, Provost, and other Senior Administrators, as well as the extent to which the leadership team cares about staff well-being were the best predictors of overall satisfaction.
 - All variables were statistically significant in this model.
- Results indicate this overall category and statistical model explains a meaningful amount of satisfaction staff may experience.

- Results were statistically significant for all years of employment, particularly for staff who have been employed for 1-4 years.

Leadership Effectiveness: Employee perceptions of the effectiveness of both the President and Provost in addressing challenges that face the university. These measures provide insight into how much trust employees have in how effective senior leadership can or will be in addressing challenges.

Variable	Standardized Coefficient b (Beta)	p-value
How effective is the University's President when it comes to addressing challenges the institution is facing?	.36	<.001**
How effective is the University's Provost when it comes to addressing challenges the institution is facing?	.01	.89

Adjusted R² = 12%

Interpretation:

- Perceptions in how effective the President is in addressing campus challenges was the best predictor of overall satisfaction for staff.
 - Staff perceive the President's role as most predictive of satisfaction compared to the Provost's role. This may depend on the nature of the challenges, where the President is more responsible for handling financial and overall challenges affecting the university.
 - Some staff positions are not academic-focused, which is primarily the role of the Provost.

Key Takeaways (Adjusted R²)

- Soft Resources: 40%
- Interactions on Campus: 37%
- Campus Leadership: 30%
- Tangible Resources: 15%
- Processes and Procedures: 15%
- Leadership Effectiveness: 12%

Largest Variables Predicting More Positive Overall Satisfaction:

- Professional Development Opportunities
- Reductions in Stress
- Feeling Welcomed
- Feeling Valued, and Having a Voice to Express Concerns

- Communication
- Feeling Respected by the Full Administration
- Leadership Effectiveness, specifically the President's role

Appendix C - OLS Model Predicting Employee Satisfaction

Variables

Satisfaction: Outcome variable capturing overall satisfaction with the institutional work environment (VAR4).

Role: Dichotomous variable indicating whether the respondent is a faculty or staff member (VAR1).

Leadership: Composite measure of institutional leadership support, including items assessing communication, opportunities to voice concerns, and perceived responsiveness and communication effectiveness from university leadership (VAR8, VAR9, VAR10, VAR19, VAR11, VAR12, VAR13, VAR26, VAR27, VAR28). Higher scores indicate stronger perceived leadership.

Organizational Support: Composite measure of immediate organizational support, including clearly defined work responsibilities, manageable workload, and access to necessary resources (VAR15, VAR16, VAR17).

Perceived Climate: Assessment of the overall institutional climate for faculty and staff, reflecting inclusivity, welcoming environment, and organizational culture (VAR3).

Perceived Recognition: Employees' perception of how valued their contributions are by the institution (VAR6).

Stress: Reported level of stress or feeling overwhelmed at work (VAR18).

Symbolic reward morale concerns: It is measured using two items capturing non-material forms of recognition and inclusion: feelings of belonging (VAR32) and feeling valued (VAR33). These items reflect employees' perceptions of symbolic acknowledgment and social affirmation within the institution. Responses were combined to form a composite measure of symbolic reward morale concern.

Material reward morale concerns: It is measured using two items measuring the perceived morale impact of tangible compensation: salary (VAR30) and benefits (VAR31). These items capture the extent to which financial rewards influence employees' morale and were combined into a single material reward morale concern index.

Resource and policy morale concerns: It is measured using items assessing the morale impact of institutional infrastructure and organizational capacity, including resources such as systems, software, and departmental budgets (VAR36) and facilities (VAR37). These items were combined to represent concerns related to the material and procedural environment in which employees perform their work.

Findings

Model 1 in Table 1 shows that morale concerns regarding material rewards are inversely related to faculty's work satisfaction ($\beta = -0.047$). This negative association appears somewhat attenuated among staff members, becoming slightly positive, although not statistically significant. It's

important to note that this finding does not suggest that material rewards are unimportant for faculty. Rather, it only suggests that the association between morale concerns about material compensation and job satisfaction does not differ significantly between faculty and staff. This finding also reflects differences in how morale-related experiences are cognitively integrated into satisfaction judgments across employee groups. This explanation is consistent with prior research indicating that in unionized academic settings, material rewards are often standardized or constrained, limiting their impact on individual perceptions of satisfaction (Freeman & Medoff, 1984; Rhoades, 1998).

Model 2 in Table 2 shows that faculty who report higher morale concerns regarding symbolic rewards are significantly less satisfied with their work ($\beta = -0.265$, $p < 0.01$). This aligns with organizational research showing that symbolic rewards, such as recognition, feelings of belonging, and being valued, are psychologically meaningful and strongly linked to satisfaction, particularly in professional or academic contexts (Baker, Dutta, & Walton, 2019; Kalleberg, 1977). For staff, that negative relationship is reversed and neutralized. This suggests that symbolic reward concerns do not meaningfully reduce satisfaction and may even be weakly positive. This does not mean symbolic rewards increase staff satisfaction. Rather, it suggests that staff satisfaction is less sensitive to symbolic reward morale concerns, and faculty integrate symbolic recognition more directly into how they evaluate their work experience.

Model 3 of Table 2 concerns the University's resources and policy show a significant negative association with faculty satisfaction ($\beta = -0.170$, $p < 0.05$). Among faculty, greater morale concerns about university resources and policies are significantly associated with lower overall work satisfaction. This suggests that when faculty perceive problems with institutional policies, governance, or resource allocation, these concerns translate directly into dissatisfaction. This makes substantive sense given faculty's dependence on shared governance, academic autonomy, and long-term resource stability for teaching and research. This association is less strong for staff than for faculty.

Discussion and Policy Implications from Organizational Sociology Perspectives

The findings highlight the central role of morale concerns, particularly those related to symbolic rewards and institutional resources and policies, in shaping employee satisfaction. While concerns about material rewards are not significantly associated with satisfaction, concerns regarding symbolic valuation—such as respect, recognition, and appreciation—and concerns about resources and policy environments are strongly and negatively related to satisfaction, especially among faculty. This pattern suggests that dissatisfaction is driven less by distributive outcomes and more by how work is valued, interpreted, and governed within the institution.

The absence of a significant relationship between material reward concerns and satisfaction is plausibly explained by the presence of a unionized employment structure, in which salaries and benefits are largely standardized and negotiated through collective bargaining. In such contexts, material compensation is relatively insulated from discretionary institutional decision-making, reducing its salience as a driver of morale (Freeman and Medoff 1984). Organizational research

suggests that when material rewards are routinized or perceived as fixed, employees are more likely to evaluate their work experience through symbolic and procedural dimensions, including recognition, voice, and fairness in organizational processes (Lamont 2012; Tyler and Blader 2003).

In contrast, symbolic rewards remain highly consequential because they are closely tied to professional identity and moral evaluation, particularly in expert organizations such as universities. Sociological scholarship on professional work emphasizes that faculty morale is deeply connected to whether expertise is acknowledged, judgment is respected, and contributions are treated as meaningful rather than merely instrumental (Abbott 1988; Anteby 2010). The strong negative association between symbolic reward concerns and satisfaction—and the amplified effect for faculty—suggests that when faculty perceive erosion in respect, recognition, or professional standing, dissatisfaction emerges even in the presence of adequate material compensation.

Morale concerns related to resources and institutional policies further underscore the moral and interpretive dimensions of organizational life. Research on the sociology of evaluation and quantification shows that policies and resource allocation systems often carry implicit judgments about whose work counts, which activities are prioritized, and what forms of knowledge are valued (Espeland and Stevens 2008; Sauder and Espeland 2009). When faculty experience policies as constraining professional judgment or as imposed without meaningful consultation, morale concerns intensify—not simply because of resource scarcity, but because such policies signal a misalignment between institutional authority and professional expertise. The significant interaction effects indicate that faculty are particularly sensitive to these signals, consistent with research showing that professionals respond strongly to perceived encroachments on autonomy and discretion (Muzio, Brock, and Suddaby 2013).

From a policy perspective, these findings suggest that improving morale in higher education—especially among faculty—requires attention to the moral economy of the organization, not only its formal incentive structures. Because material rewards are often externally constrained in unionized environments, institutional leaders retain greater leverage over symbolic recognition, policy design, and the framing of faculty work. Policies that enhance transparency, respect domain expertise, and involve faculty in the interpretation and use of data for curriculum, assessment, and general education reform are likely to mitigate morale concerns more effectively than adjustments to compensation alone. Organizational scholarship consistently shows that institutions that treat professionals as knowledge-bearing assets rather than compliance subjects are better positioned to sustain commitment, learning, and adaptability over time (Heckscher and Donnellon 1994; Bernstein 2017).

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Table 2: OLS Models Predicting Employee Satisfaction

	Model 1	Model 2	Model 3
Role: Staff	0.353**	0.363**	0.353**
	(0.114)	(0.110)	(0.110)
Morale Concerns: Material Rewards	-0.047		
	(0.073)		
Morale Concerns: Symbolic Rewards		-0.265**	
		(0.093)	
Morale Concerns: Resources & Policy			-0.170*
			(0.080)
Administration Leadership	0.051*	0.048*	0.050*
	(0.023)	(0.023)	(0.023)
Institutional Support	0.345***	0.358***	0.322**
	(0.097)	(0.097)	(0.097)
Campus Climate	0.198**	0.175**	0.201**
	(0.065)	(0.064)	(0.064)
Work Recognition	0.240***	0.230***	0.232***
	(0.067)	(0.067)	(0.066)

Stress	-0.261***	-0.240***	-0.269***
	(0.049)	(0.048)	(0.048)
Staff × Material Rewards Morale Concerns	0.131		
	(0.107)		
Staff × Symbolic Rewards Morale Concerns		0.329**	
		(0.118)	
Staff × Resources & Policy Morale Concerns			0.252*
			(0.108)
Num.Obs.	238	237	238
R2	0.593	0.605	0.600
R2 Adj.	0.578	0.591	0.586
* p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001			

Appendix D - Path Analysis

Variables

Satisfaction: Outcome variable capturing overall satisfaction with the institutional work environment (VAR4).

Role: Dichotomous variable indicating whether the respondent is a faculty or staff member (VAR1).

Leadership: Composite measure of institutional leadership support, including items assessing communication, opportunities to voice concerns, and perceived responsiveness and communication effectiveness from university leadership (VAR8, VAR9, VAR10, VAR19, VAR11, VAR12, VAR13, VAR26, VAR27, VAR28). Higher scores indicate stronger perceived leadership.

Organizational Support: Composite measure of immediate organizational support, including clearly defined work responsibilities, manageable workload, and access to necessary resources (VAR15, VAR16, VAR17).

Perceived Climate: Assessment of the overall institutional climate for faculty and staff, reflecting inclusivity, welcoming environment, and organizational culture (VAR3).

Perceived Recognition: Employees' perception of how valued their contributions are by the institution (VAR6).

Stress: Reported level of stress or feeling overwhelmed at work (VAR18).

Symbolic reward morale concerns: It is measured using two items capturing non-material forms of recognition and inclusion: feelings of belonging (VAR32) and feeling valued (VAR33). These items reflect employees' perceptions of symbolic acknowledgment and social affirmation within the institution. Responses were combined to form a composite measure of symbolic reward morale concern.

Material reward morale concerns: It is measured using two items measuring the perceived morale impact of tangible compensation: salary (VAR30) and benefits (VAR31). These items capture the extent to which financial rewards influence employees' morale and were combined into a single material reward morale concern index.

Resource and policy morale concerns: It is measured using items assessing the morale impact of institutional infrastructure and organizational capacity, including resources such as systems, software, and departmental budgets (VAR36) and facilities (VAR37). These items were combined to represent concerns related to the material and procedural environment in which employees perform their work.

Findings

Table 3 and Figure 2 present the results of the path analysis examining predictors of overall satisfaction with the institutional work environment. Role is positively associated with satisfaction, with staff reporting higher levels of job satisfaction than faculty ($\beta = 0.152$, $p < 0.001$). Perceptions

of administrative leadership are directly related to higher satisfaction ($\beta = 0.206$, $p = 0.008$), and so are institutional support ($\beta = 0.173$, $p = 0.002$), campus climate ($\beta = 0.148$, $p = 0.022$), and work recognition ($\beta = 0.228$, $p = 0.002$). In contrast, departmental support is not significantly related to overall satisfaction ($\beta = 0.018$, $p = 0.653$). Stress emerges as a strong negative predictor of satisfaction ($\beta = -0.264$, $p < 0.001$). These findings align with prior research demonstrating the central role of leadership, organizational support, and recognition in shaping employee attitudes and work satisfaction (Podsakoff et al., 2009; Pfeffer, 1998; Spector, 1997).

The model also highlights several indirect effects. Leadership reduces stress, which in turn increases satisfaction ($\beta = 0.052$, $p = 0.023$). Institutional support similarly decreases stress to indirectly enhance satisfaction ($\beta = 0.104$, $p < 0.001$). Leadership also positively shapes campus climate ($\beta = 0.090$, $p = 0.025$), while institutional support enhances perceptions of work recognition ($\beta = 0.064$, $p = 0.019$), both of which indirectly boost satisfaction. These mediating effects of stress and workplace climate are consistent with research emphasizing the importance of psychosocial and environmental mechanisms linking leadership and organizational support to employee outcomes (Karasek & Theorell, 1990; Glisson & James, 2002).

Considering both direct and indirect pathways, total effects indicate that leadership ($\beta = 0.349$, $p < 0.001$) and institutional support ($\beta = 0.342$, $p < 0.001$) have substantial overall influences on employee satisfaction. These results highlight that employee satisfaction is shaped not only by direct perceptions of leadership, support, and recognition, but also indirectly through stress reduction and the enhancement of positive workplace climates, reinforcing findings from both management and sociological perspectives on organizational behavior (Freeman & Medoff, 1984; Rhoades & Eisenberger, 2002; Pfeffer, 1998).

Discussion and Policy Implications from Organizational Sociology Perspectives

The findings above demonstrate that employee satisfaction is driven primarily by institution-level conditions rather than local or departmental factors. This is consistent with organizational research showing that employees respond most strongly to system-wide leadership and support structures rather than proximal collegial relationships alone (Pfeffer 1998; Rhoades and Eisenberger 2002). Employees report higher satisfaction when they perceive strong administrative leadership, meaningful institutional support, clear recognition of their work, and a positive campus climate. In contrast, departmental support does not significantly predict overall satisfaction, which indicates that local goodwill cannot compensate for broader institutional dynamics. This is a finding aligned with sociological institutional theory emphasizing the limits of informal structures in the absence of organizational legitimacy and support (Meyer and Rowan 1977; Powell and DiMaggio 1991).

Stress emerges as a central mechanism shaping satisfaction. High stress substantially undermines satisfaction, while leadership and institutional support improve satisfaction both directly and indirectly by reducing stress and fostering healthier workplace climates. These findings reflect well-established findings in occupational sociology and management research demonstrating that psycho-social working conditions mediate the relationship between organizational structures and employee outcomes (Karasek and Theorell 1990; Glisson and James 2002). In this sense,

leadership and institutional policies matter not only because of what they symbolically signal, but because they actively structure workload demands, role clarity, and employees' capacity to manage competing expectations. The observed role-based differences—where staff report higher satisfaction than faculty—further suggest that faculty experience distinct institutional pressures or unmet expectations. This is consistent with prior research highlighting the unique governance, workload, and evaluative demands placed on academic labor (Pfeffer 1998).

Put together, these findings have important implications for institutional policy and planning. Because administrative leadership and institutional support exert the strongest total effects on satisfaction, operating through both direct influence and indirect pathways such as stress reduction and climate enhancement, employee satisfaction should be treated as an institutional strategic planning concern, not a localized, unit-level, or interpersonal issue. Research on organizational performance and sustainability consistently shows that organizations that integrate human capacity, workload sustainability, and climate into planning processes are better positioned to adapt and maintain effectiveness over time (Schein 2010; Pfeffer 1998). From a planning perspective, the strong negative impact of stress underscores the need for capacity-aware institutional strategic planning, which is supposed to be accompanied by systematic assessments of workload, resource adequacy, and implementation burden (Karasek and Theorell 1990).

The absence of a significant relationship between departmental support and overall satisfaction further suggests that institutional plans should prioritize centralized supports and cross-unit coordination mechanisms, rather than relying on departments to absorb new responsibilities without commensurate resources. Organizational scholarship has long cautioned that such arrangements shift risk downward while preserving authority at the center, producing strain without improving outcomes (Meyer and Rowan 1977; Powell and DiMaggio 1991). The findings also support embedding transparent governance and feedback practices into institutional planning, including early cross-unit consultation, clear documentation of decision rationales and tradeoffs, and feedback closure explaining how employee input informed outcomes. Prior research demonstrates that transparency, procedural fairness, and opportunities for voice strengthen organizational climate, reduce stress, and enhance perceptions of leadership legitimacy (Glisson and James 2002; Pfeffer 1998).

More broadly, the findings align with a substantial body of research in organizational sociology and management showing that organizational climate is a critical determinant of performance, adaptability, and long-term sustainability, particularly in complex, professionalized organizations such as higher education. Climate shapes how employees interpret leadership actions, experience workload demands, and assess whether their contributions are valued, thereby influencing motivation, commitment, and discretionary effort (Schein 2010; Pfeffer 1998). Organizational sociology further emphasizes that climate contributes to organizational legitimacy and stability by shaping shared norms and expectations that guide behavior beyond formal structures (Meyer and Rowan 1977; Powell and DiMaggio 1991). Empirical studies demonstrate that positive climate conditions, which are characterized by psychological safety, procedural fairness, and manageable demands, are associated with higher effectiveness, reduced burnout, and greater capacity for

organizational learning and change (Karasek and Theorell 1990; Glisson and James 2002). In higher education specifically, where work relies heavily on professional autonomy, collaboration, and intrinsic motivation, organizational climate functions as a key resource. When climate deteriorates, organizations experience declining engagement, weakened governance capacity, and diminished ability to implement strategic initiatives, ultimately undermining institutional sustainability.

Specifically, the findings have particular implications for faculty work in core academic processes such as curriculum development and academic program assessment, where effective decision-making depends on the integration of professional expertise and evidence-based inquiry. Research on organizational learning emphasizes that data do not generate improvement on their own; rather, their value depends on how they are interpreted, contextualized, and acted upon by domain experts embedded in the work itself (Argyris and Schön 1996; March 1991). In higher education, faculty are uniquely positioned to interpret assessment data, enrollment trends, and learning outcomes in ways that are pedagogically meaningful and institutionally relevant. When data-driven planning is imposed through top-down mandates or compliance-oriented reporting structures, organizations often experience ritualized use of data that satisfies formal requirements without producing learning or improvement (Meyer and Rowan 1977; Espeland and Stevens 2008). In contrast, studies of effective academic change show that data contribute to organizational sustainability and adaptability when they are used as tools for collective inquiry and problem-solving, embedded within faculty-led curricular and assessment processes (Kezar 2014; Bensimon, Dowd, and Witham 2012).

Sustainable performance in professional organizations depends on leadership's ability to create systems that support evidence-informed, bottom-up collaboration rather than unilateral decision-making. Extensive research demonstrates that organizations learn and adapt most effectively when leaders enable feedback loops, protect professional judgment, and treat data as a resource for sensemaking rather than as an instrument of control (Argyris 2004; Edmondson 2018). In such systems, transparency about assumptions, constraints, and tradeoffs allows faculty and staff to align expertise with institutional goals, strengthening trust and psychological safety—conditions shown to be essential for learning, innovation, and long-term effectiveness (Edmondson and Lei 2014). Conversely, framing faculty as obstacles to efficiency or as labor to be managed rather than as organizational assets undermines climate, increases stress, and weakens institutional capacity for adaptation (Pfeffer 1998; Adler 2012). For curriculum reform and general education revision in particular, the evidence suggests that true leadership lies in working with faculty expertise and data together, treating faculty not as sources of resistance but as critical organizational resources whose knowledge is indispensable to data-driven planning, institutional learning, and long-term sustainability.

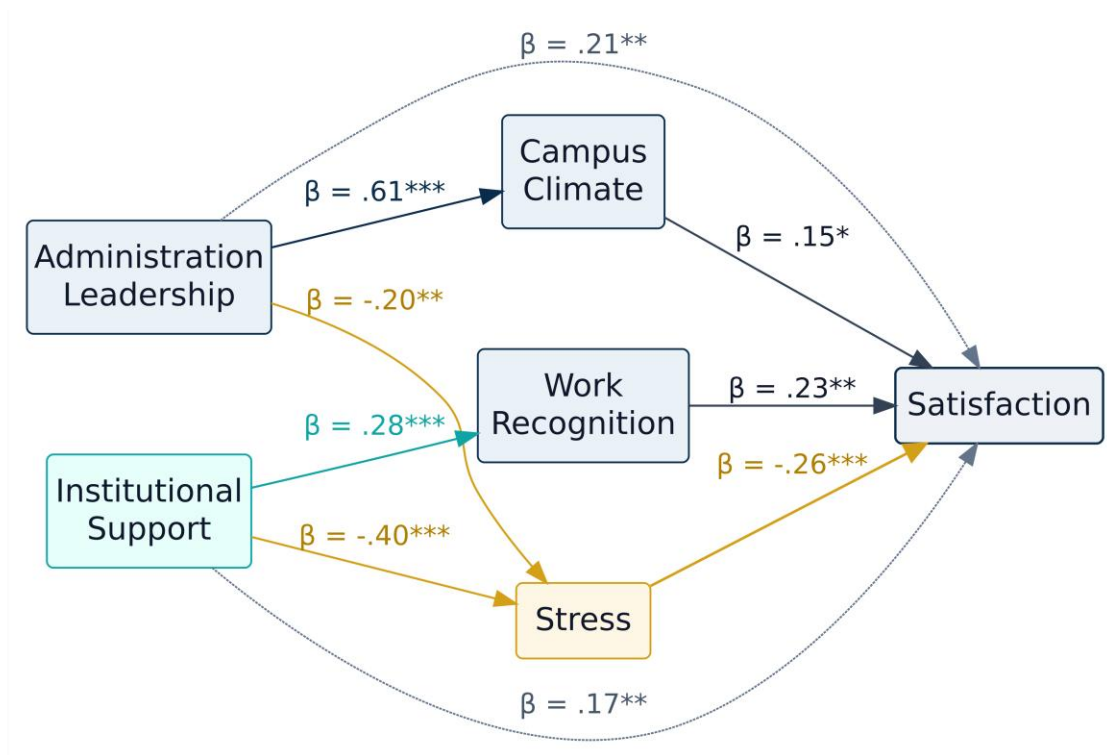
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Table 3: Path Analysis of Overall Satisfaction with the Institutional Work Environment

Predictor	Estimate	SE	z	p-value	Type
Role: Staff	0.152***	0.045	3.347	0.000800	Direct
Administration Leadership	0.206**	0.078	2.654	0.008000	Direct
Institutional Support	0.173**	0.056	3.104	0.001900	Direct
Department Support	0.018	0.041	0.450	0.653000	Direct
Campus Climate	0.148*	0.064	2.297	0.021600	Direct
Work Recognition	0.228**	0.075	3.032	0.002400	Direct
Stress	-0.264***	0.064	-4.095	0.000040	Direct
Leadership → Stress	0.052*	0.023	2.274	0.023000	Indirect
Institutional Support → Stress	0.104***	0.031	3.319	0.000900	Indirect
Leadership → Climate	0.09*	0.040	2.243	0.024900	Indirect
Institutional Support → Recognition	0.064*	0.027	2.352	0.018700	Indirect
Total Leadership	0.349***	0.074	4.705	0.000003	Total
Total Institutional	0.342***	0.058	5.846	0.000000	Total

Figure 2: SEM Path Analysis of Employee Satisfaction



Appendix E - Topic Modeling

Methodology

To identify recurring themes in faculty and staff open-ended survey responses, we employed structural topic modeling (STM). STM is a probabilistic text modeling approach that identifies latent topics as distributions over words while estimating each document's mixture of topics (Roberts et al., 2014). Unlike traditional topic models, STM allows topic prevalence to vary across documents and supports integration with metadata (Ho 2022).

All open-ended responses were concatenated into a single comment field and preprocessed using standard text-as-data procedures, including lowercasing, tokenization, and removal of common stopwords. The final corpus consisted of 102 comments for faculty, each representing an individual response.

We estimated multiple STM specifications and selected a six-topic and a five-topic solution ($K = 7$ for faculty and $K = 6$ for staff) based on a combination of semantic coherence, exclusivity, and interpretability. Topic-word distributions were extracted from the model's β (beta) matrix, representing the probability of each word given a topic. For each topic, we examined the top 25 highest-probability words to characterize the substantive meaning of the topic.

Document-level topic proportions (θ , theta) were also extracted, allowing each response to be represented as a mixture of topics rather than assigned to a single category.

Topics were labeled through an iterative interpretive process combining (1) inspection of high-probability words and (2) close reading of documents with the highest topic proportions (θ) for each topic. This mixed quantitative–qualitative approach helps ensure topic labels reflected not only lexical patterns but also the lived concerns expressed in respondents' own words.

One important limitation of the topic modeling results concerns the varying response rates to the qualitative questions. In particular, the question asking respondents to specify additional factors affecting morale had a high missing rate (approximately 85%), while the questions on institutional climate (37% missing) and suggestions for improving morale (26% missing) received substantially more responses. As a result, the STM findings should be interpreted as reflecting the themes present among those who chose to provide written comments rather than the views of the entire survey population. In addition, individual responses display a wide range of perspectives. Some comments express frustration with colleagues or local workplace dynamics, while others voice support for administrative decisions or institutional policies. Topic modeling does not capture every individual viewpoint; rather, it identifies patterns of language that appear most frequently across the corpus. The topics presented here therefore represent the statistically dominant themes in the qualitative responses, highlighting common areas of concern and experience, while less frequent or idiosyncratic perspectives may not appear as distinct topics in the model.

It is also important to clarify that topic modeling does not treat individual comments as direct statements of objective organizational reality. Rather, the method identifies patterns of language across many responses to detect common, and sometimes less immediately visible, themes

embedded in the corpus. In this sense, qualitative comments are not taken at face value as isolated claims but are analyzed as expressions of respondents' perceptions, interpretations, and psychological orientations toward their workplace. From an organizational sociology perspective, these responses can be understood as reflections of how employees experience and interpret institutional conditions. Employees' attitudes, concerns, and evaluations are shaped by the organizational structures within which they work, including authority relations, resource distribution, governance practices, and labor arrangements. Topic modeling therefore helps reveal how these structural conditions are collectively experienced and articulated in employees' language, offering insight into the organizational processes that shape satisfaction, morale, and institutional trust.

Findings

Faculty Topic 1: Institutional Care, Treatment, and Moral Climate

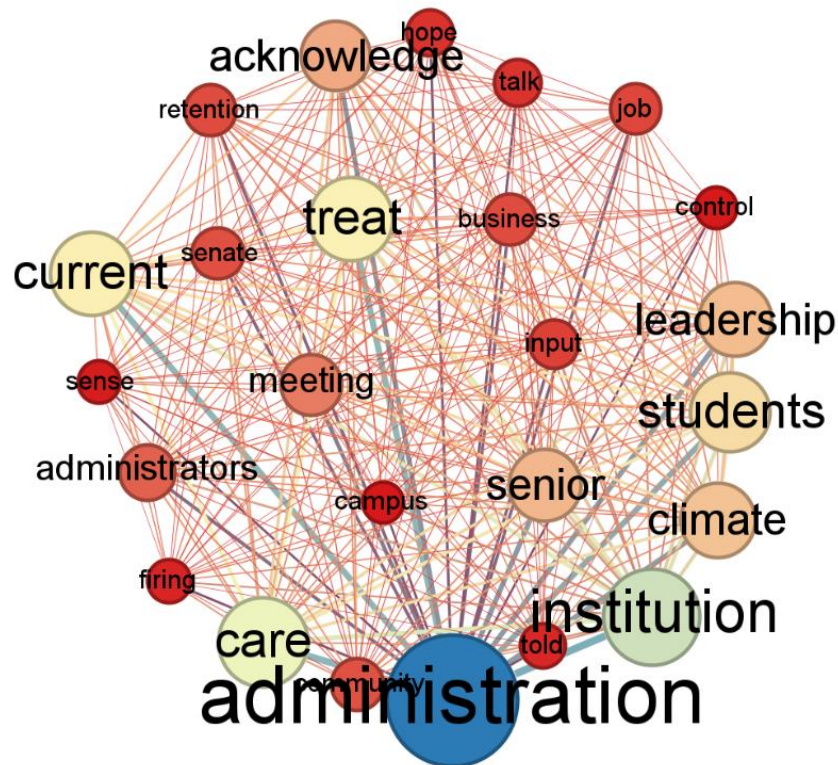
Topic 1 captures faculty concerns about how the administration treats members of the campus community and whether institutional actions reflect care, respect, and ethical responsibility. High-theta documents consistently frame administrative behavior in moral terms, suggesting that perceptions of care and humane treatment are central to how faculty evaluate institutional climate. Respondents emphasize that administrative actions are experienced not merely as inefficient or unclear, but as actively harmful or dismissive of human well-being.

One respondent stated, “Feeling VERY overwhelmed and as if the institution does not care about my wellbeing... complete burnout of myself.”

Another reflected on the erosion of community over time, noting, “When I started here over a decade ago it felt like a family... Now it is a ghost town. There is no belonging. No sense of community.”

Others explicitly attribute harm to leadership choices, describing them as “devastating” and rooted in “mismanagement” and “incompetence.” Taken together, these excerpts suggest that Topic 1 reflects a moral evaluation of institutional conduct, in which care and ethical responsibility are viewed as foundational to a healthy campus climate.

Figure 3: Faculty Topic 1 - Institutional Care, Treatment, and Moral Climate



Faculty Topic 2: Governance, Trustees, and Fiscal Accountability

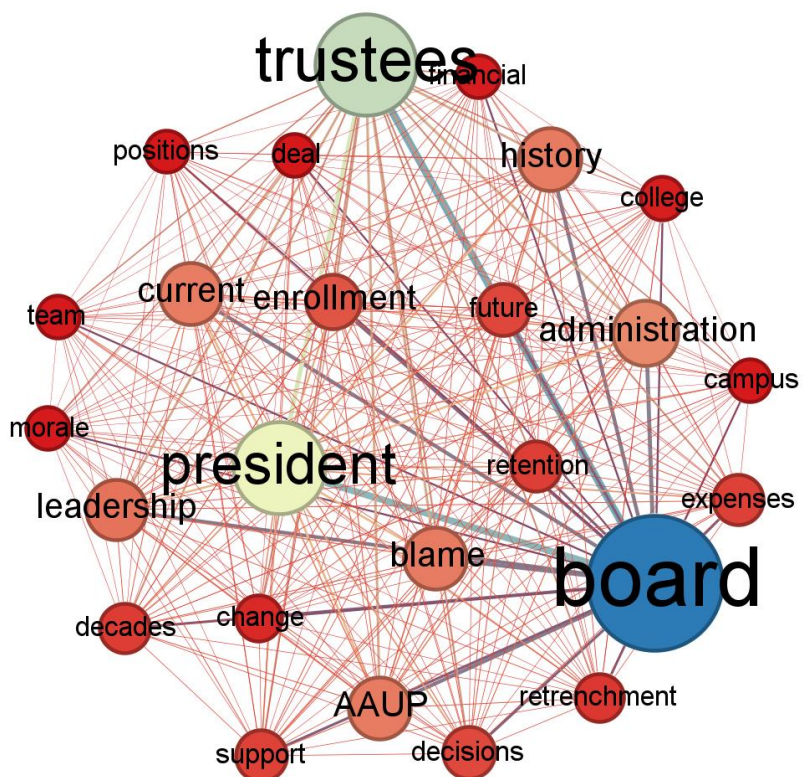
Topic 2 centers on formal governance structures and financial accountability, with particular emphasis on the Board of Trustees, senior leadership, and labor relations involving the AAUP. High-probability responses link institutional decision-making to fiscal priorities and express concern about who bears responsibility for financial missteps. Faculty repeatedly emphasize the need for transparency around expenses, revenue, and strategic choices, especially in moments of retrenchment.

One respondent argued, “Cutting 30 jobs and related programs at once is terrible... the expansion in FL and downtown was a huge misstep and Utica is paying the price for it now.”

Another stressed the importance of openness, stating, “Inform the faculty about the financial benchmarks... dragging your feet gives the impression you have something to hide.”

Several comments frame governance as a site of blame and accountability, asserting that financial crises are the result of leadership decisions rather than external forces. Collectively, these comments indicate that Topic 2 reflects concerns about power, responsibility, and legitimacy in institutional governance.

Figure 4: Faculty Topic 2 - Governance, Trustees, and Fiscal Accountability



Faculty Topic 3: Community, Morale, and the Institutional Future

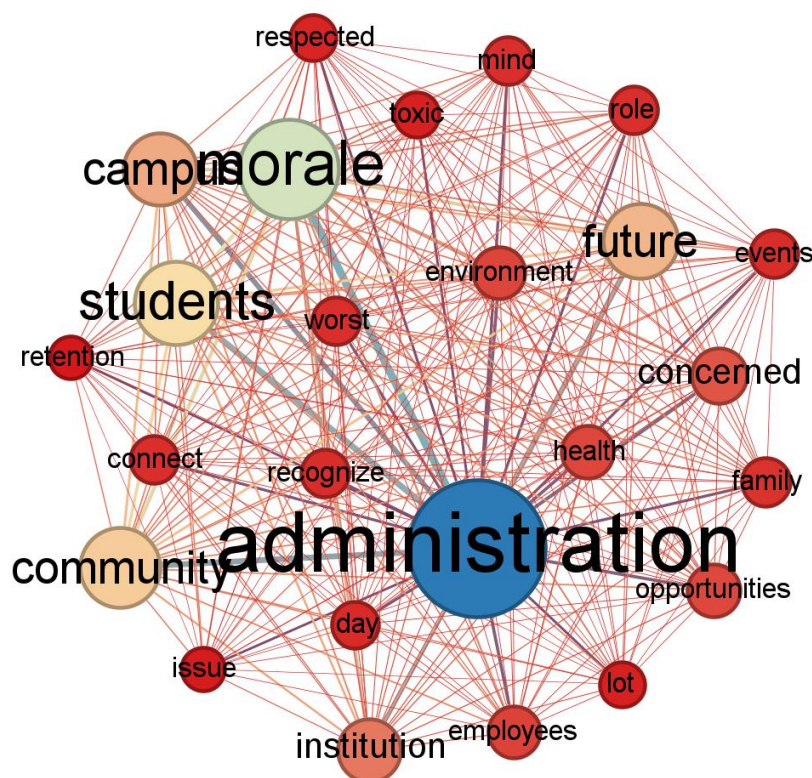
Topic 3 reflects collective concerns about morale, community cohesion, and the future direction of the institution. High-theta documents emphasize shared emotional conditions rather than individual grievances, framing morale as something that spreads across the campus and shapes long-term institutional prospects.

One respondent observed, “Morale, both high and low, is catching... it creates an atmosphere of fear and uncertainty; a sensation that anything could happen.”

Another highlighted the forward-looking nature of these concerns, noting the need for “opportunities for improvement” and renewed connection.

Several comments express anxiety about division and disconnection, while also gesturing toward the possibility of rebuilding community if leadership choices change. Taken together, these excerpts suggest that Topic 3 captures a collective emotional horizon oriented toward the institution’s future rather than immediate blame.

Figure 5: Faculty Topic 3 - Community, Morale, and the Institutional Future



Faculty Topic 4: Transparency, Communication, and Trust

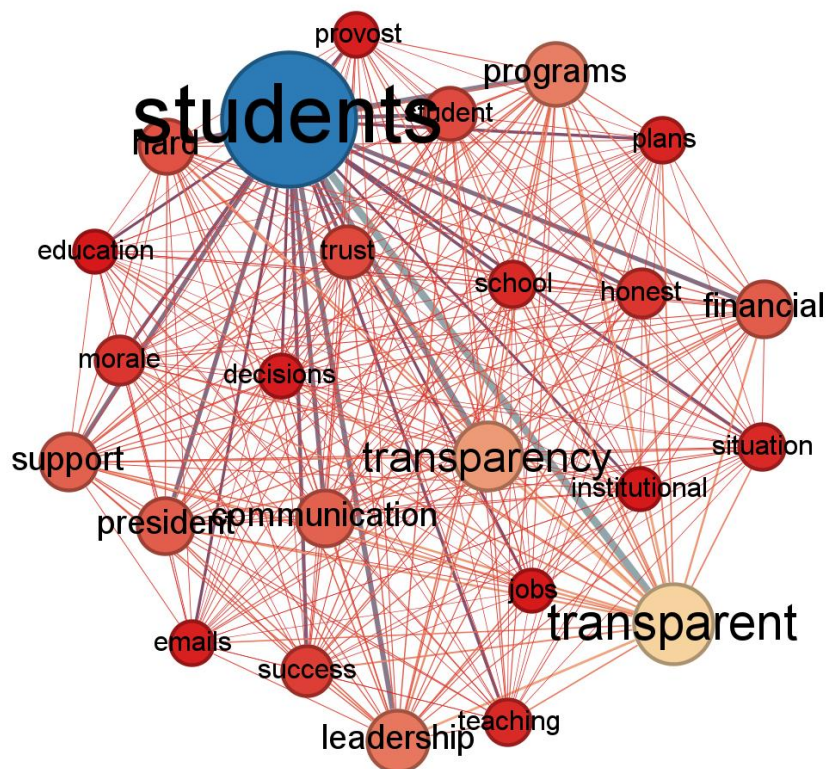
Topic 4 captures faculty concerns about transparency, communication, and the erosion of trust during periods of institutional change. High-probability documents consistently link unclear or delayed communication to heightened anxiety and speculation, suggesting that transparency is viewed as a prerequisite for trust.

One respondent wrote, “More transparent communication about institutional decisions and plans for sustainability would help rebuild trust and confidence.”

Another criticized existing practices, stating, “Stop communicating through press conferences... communicate clearly and reasonably when there is a plan.”

Others emphasized the need for detailed information and advance notice, arguing that a lack of clarity creates confusion and undermines confidence. Collectively, these responses indicate that Topic 4 reflects procedural concerns about how decisions are communicated and how trust is maintained in times of uncertainty.

Figure 6: Faculty Topic 4 - Transparency, Communication, and Trust



Topic 5 focuses on the structural conditions of academic labor, including workload, tenure and promotion processes, and burnout. High-theta comments describe excessive demands, uneven distribution of labor, and insufficient support, particularly for faculty navigating career progression.

Another called for “fair equity of workload across all faculty, staff, and leadership,” emphasizing systemic imbalance.

Figure 7: Faculty Topic 5 - Academic Labor, Workload, and Career Structure



Faculty Topic 6: Compensation, Recognition, and Workplace Value

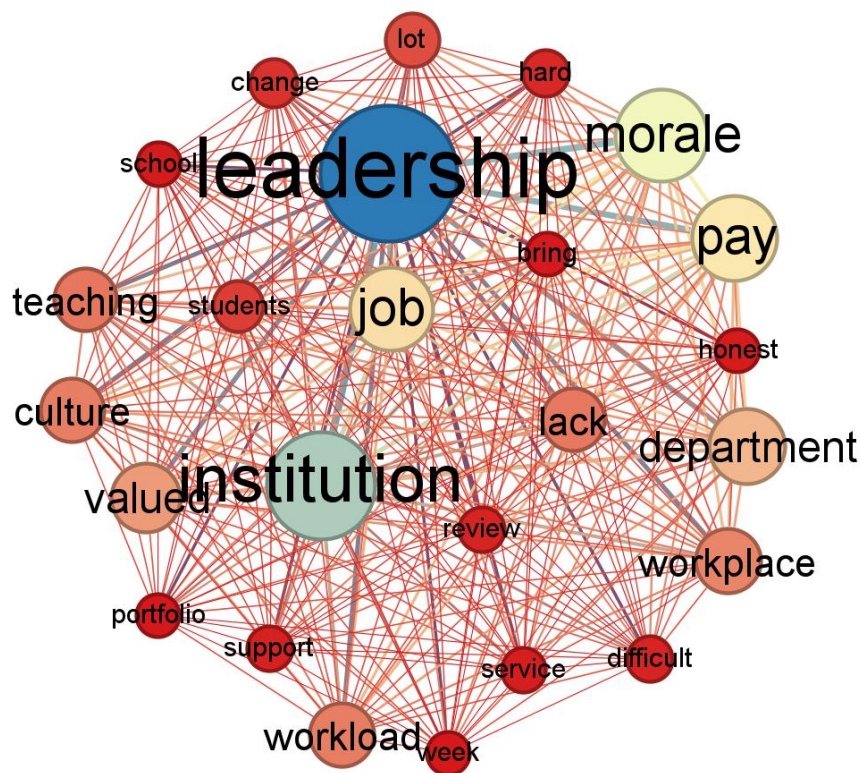
Topic 6 captures concerns about compensation, recognition, and whether faculty and staff feel materially and symbolically valued by the institution. High-probability documents frequently contrast rising expectations with declining pay and benefits, especially in the context of inflation.

One respondent argued, “It is completely outlandish to ask someone to work the same for less money during a time when inflation is making it difficult to live comfortably.”

Another stated bluntly, “Stop asking for equal or more work for less money.” Other comments emphasize the absence of recognition for extraordinary effort, noting that sacrifices made during crises go largely unacknowledged.

Collectively, these excerpts frame compensation as a key site where institutional values are enacted—or violated—in everyday work life.

Figure 8: Faculty Topic 6 - Compensation, Recognition, and Workplace Value



Faculty Topic 7: Academic Programs, Gen Ed, and Retrenchment Processes

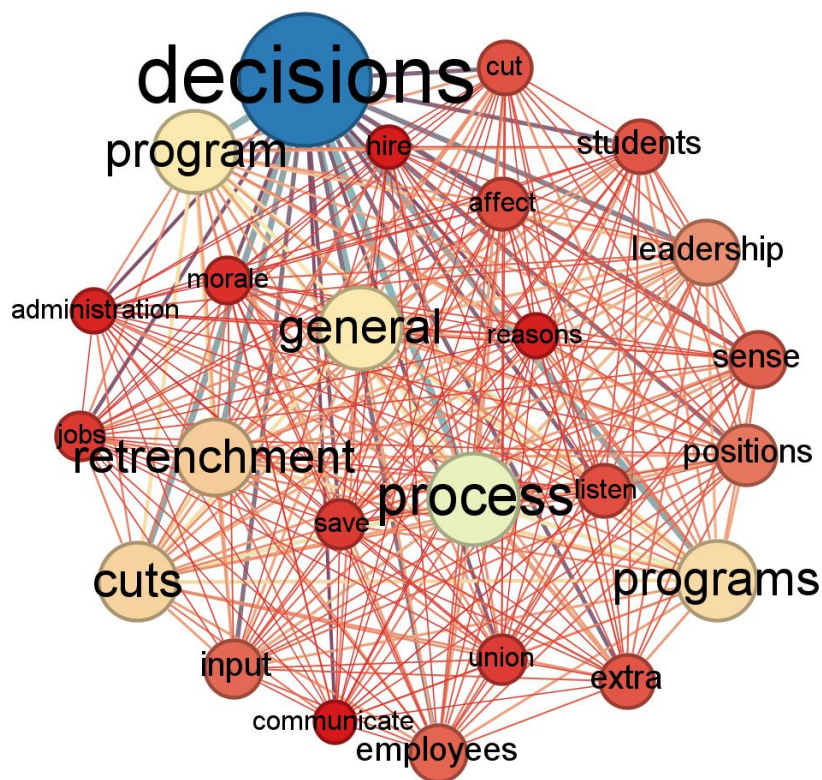
Topic 7 centers on curricular change, Gen Ed revisions, and retrenchment, with particular emphasis on the processes through which these changes are implemented. High-theta documents describe a persistent “state of emergency,” marked by rushed timelines, overlapping initiatives, and limited faculty input.

One respondent recounted, “It was the need to revise Gen Ed in a pandemic... an extremely burdensome workload and accompanying sense that if we don’t do this NOW everything will fall apart.”

Another noted that simultaneous retrenchment and portfolio review felt “nonsensical and adds to the chaotic atmosphere of fear and uncertainty.”

Several comments criticize the framing of decisions as notices rather than consultation, arguing that this undermines respect and voice. Taken together, these excerpts suggest that Topic 7 reflects not only opposition to program cuts, but deep frustration with how institutional change is managed.

Figure 9: Faculty Topic 7 - Academic Programs, Gen Ed, and Retrenchment Processes



Findings from Faculty Topics from Organizational Sociology Perspectives

Across seven faculty topics, the STM results reveal a coherent and multi-layered account of organizational strain shaped by moral evaluation, governance practices, affective climate, labor conditions, and institutional change processes. Rather than representing isolated complaints, the topics collectively point to systemic tensions embedded in authority relations, decision-making processes, symbolic valuation, and the organization of professional work. From an organizational sociology perspective, these themes reflect the interaction of structural arrangements and lived experience through which institutional legitimacy, trust, and commitment are sustained—or undermined.

Several topics foreground concerns about leadership, transparency, and procedural legitimacy, indicating that faculty evaluations of the institution are strongly shaped by how decisions are made and communicated. Topics centered on transparency, governance, and administrative treatment consistently emphasize opacity, rushed processes, and limited consultation. This pattern aligns closely with sociological research on organizational legitimacy and procedural justice, which demonstrates that acceptance of authority depends not only on outcomes but on whether decision-making processes are perceived as fair, intelligible, and participatory (Brockner et al. 2001; Tyler and Blader 2003). When decisions are experienced as opaque, post hoc, or imposed, authority is more likely to be interpreted as arbitrary rather than legitimate. The prominence of these topics thus signals a breakdown in what organizational scholars describe as the relational foundations of authority (Hechter and Opp 2001).

The emergence of moral and relational evaluations of care and treatment as a distinct topic further extends this argument. Faculty responses do not frame institutional problems solely in technical or managerial terms, but instead invoke ethical judgments about whether the institution acts with care, respect, and responsibility toward its members. This moral framing suggests that organizational strain is experienced not only as inefficiency or mismanagement, but as a form of moral injury. Such findings resonate with prior research on dignity, recognition, and worth in organizations, which emphasizes that perceived disregard or mistreatment can be as consequential as material loss in shaping disaffection and withdrawal (Lamont 2012).

Affective dimensions of organizational life also appear prominently. Topics centered on morale, community, and the institutional future demonstrate that strain is experienced collectively and emotionally, rather than as individualized burnout alone. Organizational scholarship increasingly emphasizes that morale is a relational and emergent phenomenon, shaped by shared interpretations of uncertainty, belonging, and voice (Kahn 1990; Barsade and O'Neill 2014). The clustering of morale-related language into a distinct topic indicates that respondents understand emotional exhaustion and anxiety as socially produced conditions, linked to ongoing organizational dynamics rather than personal inadequacy.

At the same time, faculty clearly distinguish between symbolic and material dimensions of work, as reflected in separate topics addressing academic labor conditions and compensation. Topics focused on workload, tenure, promotion, and burnout highlight the structural organization of

academic labor and the uneven distribution of demands and support. In contrast, topics centered on pay, recognition, and inflation foreground the material valuation of labor and the mismatch between expectations and rewards. This separation mirrors findings in organizational sociology showing that symbolic recognition and material compensation operate through distinct mechanisms and independently shape commitment and identification (Stephens et al. 2014). The topic structure suggests that faculty differentiate between being overworked, being underpaid, and being undervalued—each constituting a distinct source of strain.

Finally, the prominence of a topic devoted to academic programs, Gen Ed reform, and retrenchment processes highlights how organizational change itself becomes a focal site of conflict. Faculty responses emphasize not only the substance of curricular cuts or revisions, but the pace, sequencing, and framing of change initiatives. This finding aligns with neo-institutional research documenting how formal governance structures can become decoupled from actual decision-making practices, producing frustration and cynicism among organizational members (Meyer and Rowan 1977; Bromley and Powell 2012). More recent work further suggests that when participation is perceived as symbolic rather than consequential, it undermines trust and weakens organizational identification (Hallett 2010; Huising and Silbey 2011). The retrenchment and Gen Ed topic reflects acute awareness of this gap between shared governance ideals and lived institutional practice.

Taken together, the seven topics depict organizational strain as a multidimensional condition produced through the interaction of authority structures, moral evaluations, affective climates, labor arrangements, and change processes. Rather than pointing to a single source of dissatisfaction, the findings suggest that faculty experience institutional life as shaped by overlapping organizational dynamics that jointly erode trust, morale, and professional commitment. Importantly, the topic structure indicates that respondents are able to distinguish among these dimensions, underscoring that organizational strain is not a diffuse sentiment but a patterned response to identifiable institutional processes.

Staff Topic 1: Team-Based Work Organization and Role Flexibility

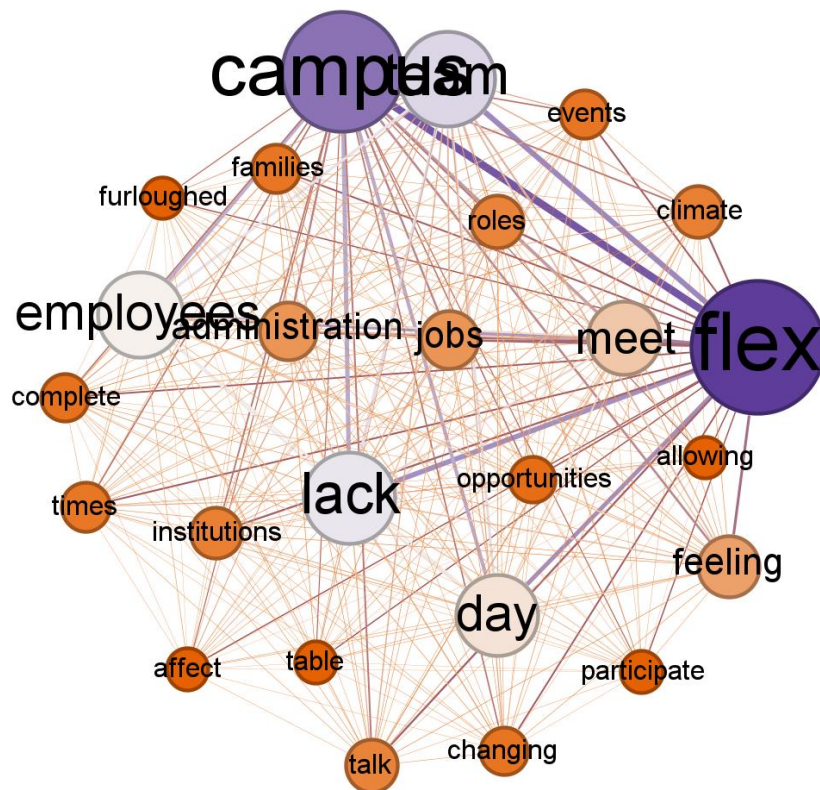
Topic 1 centers on the organization of daily staff work, with particular emphasis on role flexibility, team coordination, and shifting expectations across departments. High-theta documents describe a workplace in which staff are expected to adapt continuously to changing roles and procedures, often without clear guidance or stable routines.

One respondent noted, “There never seems to be an exact set way of doing things here... things are constantly changing, and I feel like it’s hardly ever for the better.”

Another described the cumulative strain of this instability, observing that “there is a stress and anxiety around the whole campus that always feels palpable.”

Several comments emphasize that flexibility, particularly FlexWork, has become essential to coping with these demands, with one staff member stating, “FlexWork is really one of the main things keeping people here right now.” Taken together, these excerpts suggest that Topic 1 reflects both the operational realities of staff labor and the reliance on flexibility as a compensatory mechanism for organizational instability.

Figure 10: Staff Topic 1 - Team-Based Work Organization and Role Flexibility



Staff Topic 2: Staffing Capacity, Care, and Recognition

Topic 2 captures staff concerns about whether the institution is adequately staffed and whether employees feel cared for and recognized within their roles. High-probability comments link understaffing to diminished well-being and a sense that staff labor is taken for granted.

One respondent remarked, “Leadership says we are overstaffed, but I beg to differ. Most offices could use way more help for the amount of traffic they see.”

Another emphasized the emotional dimension of this experience, stating, “Other than from my own department, I never really feel like the University cares about the work I do, and it’s upsetting.”

Several comments connect staffing levels to health and morale, noting that chronic shortages intensify stress and erode recognition. Collectively, these excerpts indicate that Topic 2 reflects staff perceptions of institutional care as expressed through staffing decisions and acknowledgment of labor.

Figure 11: Staff Topic 2 - Staffing Capacity, Care, and Recognition



Staff Topic 3: Positions, Titles, and Organizational Change

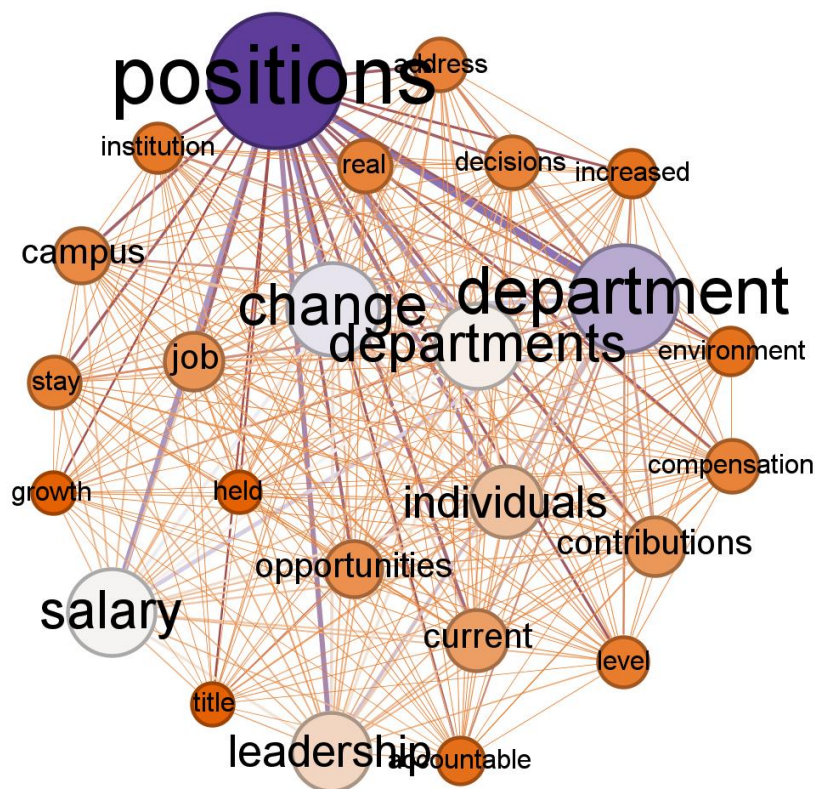
Topic 3 focuses on structural change within departments, including shifting positions, altered titles, and unclear pathways for growth. High-theta documents describe organizational change as frequent and uneven, leaving staff uncertain about their roles and futures.

One respondent observed that “positions keep changing, but it’s never clear how those changes actually help the people doing the work.”

Another noted the emotional toll of these shifts, explaining that “it hurts to feel like your role can be changed or redefined without honest communication.”

Several comments emphasize the lack of clarity around growth and advancement, suggesting that change is experienced as destabilizing rather than developmental. Taken together, these excerpts suggest that Topic 3 reflects staff experiences of organizational restructuring as disruptive and insufficiently transparent.

Figure 12: Staff Topic 3 - Positions, Titles, and Organizational Change



Staff Topic 4: Budget Cuts, Workload, and Economic Strain

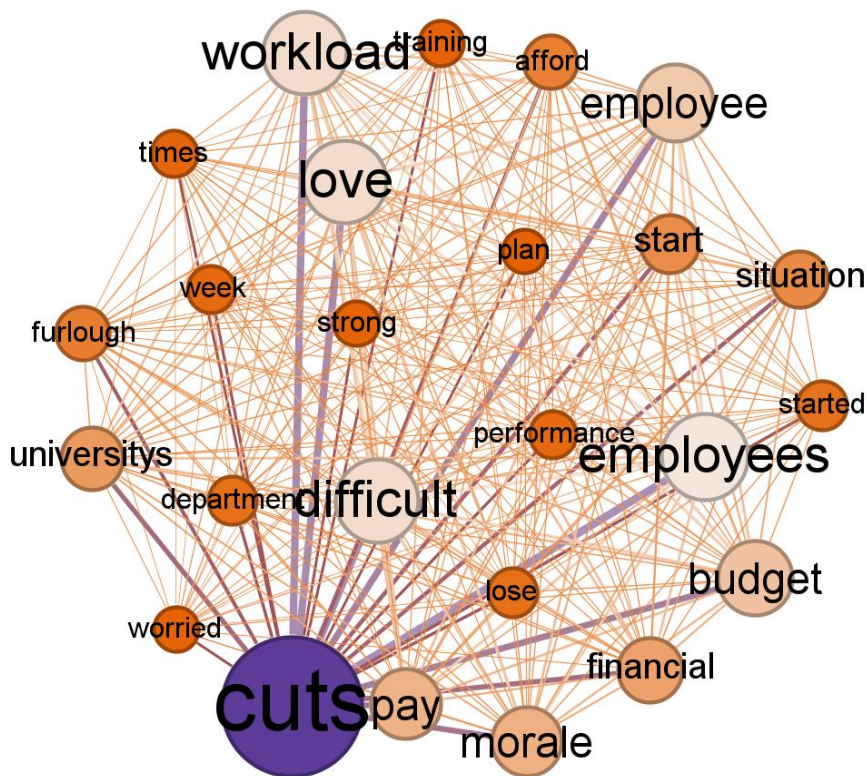
Topic 4 centers on the lived consequences of budget cuts, intensified workload, and personal financial precarity. High-probability comments describe how austerity measures translate directly into increased labor demands and heightened anxiety about meeting basic needs.

One respondent stated, “The furlough announcement really stressed me out as I live paycheck to paycheck.”

Another explained, “The cuts in staffing have increased workload for most... increased workload with salary and benefit cuts is difficult on morale.”

Several comments emphasize the cumulative impact of repeated cuts, with one staff member noting, “Two years of cuts is enough... staff feels taken advantage of year after year.” Together, these excerpts indicate that Topic 4 reflects frontline experiences of austerity as both economic and emotional strain.

Figure 13: Staff Topic 4 - Budget Cuts, Workload, and Economic Strain



Staff Topic 5: Student-Facing Coordination and Institutional Communication

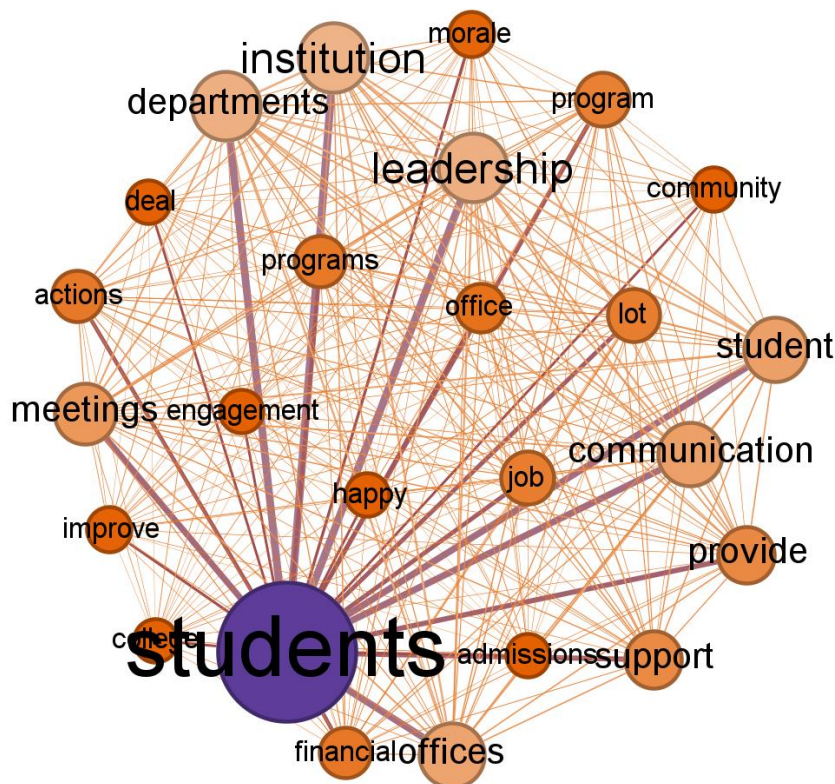
Topic 5 captures staff experiences at the interface between the institution and students, particularly around communication, coordination across offices, and the consequences of program changes for students. High-theta documents describe the emotional burden of conveying institutional limitations to students and navigating siloed departmental structures.

One respondent wrote, “My morale drops whenever I have to tell a student that they can’t take a class or pursue a major because it is no longer offered.”

Another emphasized coordination challenges, stating, “Departments work in silos and don’t interact outside of their area.”

Several comments highlight frustration with how institutional priorities are communicated to students, suggesting that staff often absorb the emotional fallout of decisions they did not make. Taken together, these excerpts suggest that Topic 5 reflects the relational and communicative labor staff perform on behalf of the institution.

Figure 14: Staff Topic 5 - Student-Facing Coordination and Institutional Communication



Staff Topic 6: Benefits, Pay, Retirement, and Morale

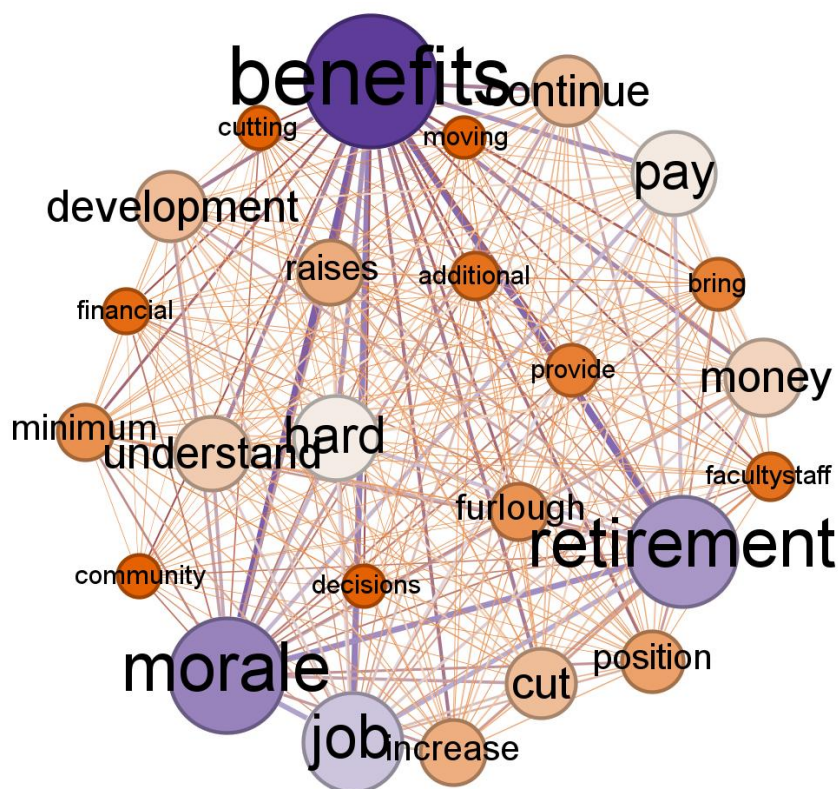
Topic 6 centers on material security and its relationship to morale, focusing on benefits, pay, retirement, and uncertainty about the future. High-probability comments consistently link declining benefits to emotional exhaustion and loss of trust.

One respondent stated, “Cutting benefits, retirement matching, and a forced furlough is hard to outweigh with any smaller movements.”

Another explained that “the lack of job security really makes morale low and adds an extreme amount to the stress of everyday life.”

Several comments emphasize that non-monetary benefits such as FlexWork and time off have become critical substitutes for financial compensation, with one noting, “In a time where additional financial benefits are not possible, personal time is even more important.” Taken together, these excerpts suggest that Topic 6 reflects how material conditions and morale are tightly intertwined in staff experiences of organizational strain.

Figure 15: Staff Topic 6 - Benefits, Pay, Retirement, and Morale



Findings from Staff Topics from Organizational Sociology Perspectives

Across six staff topics, the STM results reveal a coherent pattern of organizational strain rooted in material insecurity, labor intensification, ongoing organizational change, and uneven institutional support. Staff responses center on compensation and benefits, workload pressures associated with budget cuts, shifting roles and positions, daily work organization and flexibility, student-facing coordination, and the adequacy of leadership communication. From an organizational sociology perspective, these themes reflect structural inequalities in how organizational change, resource allocation, and authority are experienced by non-faculty workers, rather than isolated expressions of dissatisfaction.

Concerns about pay, benefits, and material security emerge as a central dimension of staff experience. Research consistently demonstrates that compensation functions not only as a material resource but also as a symbolic signal of organizational value and status (Kalleberg 2011; Rivera 2020). In the staff topics, benefits, pay, and retirement are closely linked to morale and future uncertainty, suggesting that economic insecurity is experienced simultaneously as financial strain and institutional devaluation. The consolidation of these concerns into a single topic indicates that staff do not distinguish sharply between material reward and symbolic recognition; rather, compensation is understood as a primary indicator of whether their labor is valued by the institution.

Workload pressures associated with budget cuts and staffing reductions represent a second major axis of strain. Organizational scholarship on austerity and labor intensification shows that budget contractions often redistribute work downward, increasing demands on frontline employees while constraining their discretion and resources (Clawson and Gerstel 2014; Damaske 2021). The prominence of a topic centered on cuts, workload, and difficulty suggests that staff experience these pressures not as temporary disruptions but as durable features of organizational restructuring. Repeated cuts appear to produce cumulative strain, particularly when increased responsibilities are not accompanied by additional support or compensation.

Staff responses also highlight the burdens associated with organizational change and positional instability. Topics focused on shifting roles, positions, and departmental restructuring suggest that change is experienced as frequent, uneven, and insufficiently explained. Prior research emphasizes that continuous organizational transformation can generate uncertainty and disengagement when workers have limited control over implementation and limited access to clear information (Stensaker and Meyer 2012; Kellogg 2019). The emergence of change as a distinct topic indicates that staff are not inherently resistant to change, but are sensitive to how change affects role clarity, career trajectories, and perceptions of fairness.

The topic centered on daily work organization and flexibility underscores the importance of everyday arrangements in shaping staff well-being and effectiveness. Sociological research on job quality emphasizes that predictability, manageable pace, and scheduling flexibility are central components of organizational inequality, often varying systematically by occupational status (Williams, Blair-Loy, and Berdahl 2013; Cha and Weeden 2014). The salience of flexibility and team-

based coordination suggests that staff rely heavily on informal accommodations to manage intensified workloads and shifting expectations, particularly in contexts of limited staffing and ongoing change.

Staff experiences at the student-facing interface of the institution constitute another distinct dimension of strain. A topic centered on communication, coordination across offices, and interactions with students highlights the relational labor staff perform on behalf of the institution. Research on emotional and service labor demonstrates that workers who serve as intermediaries between organizational decisions and client populations often absorb frustration and disappointment generated by decisions they did not make (Hochschild 1983). The prominence of this topic suggests that staff bear a disproportionate share of the emotional consequences of program changes, admissions constraints, and institutional communication gaps.

Finally, themes related to institutional support, training, and leadership communication reflect broader concerns about organizational capacity and relational coordination. Effective communication and training are critical mechanisms through which organizations enable workers to adapt to new demands and perform their roles competently (Gittell 2016). When leadership communication is perceived as inconsistent or insufficient, staff may experience heightened stress and reduced efficacy, even when they remain committed to their work. The clustering of communication, inclusion, and leadership messaging into a single topic indicates that staff assess institutional support primarily through the quality of information, guidance, and inclusion they receive.

Taken together, these six topics suggest that staff experiences are shaped by the interaction of material conditions, organizational restructuring, and everyday work realities. Compensation, workload, change, flexibility, communication, and student-facing labor are not experienced in isolation; rather, they combine to produce a cumulative sense of organizational strain. This pattern highlights how institutional decisions—particularly those related to austerity and change management—are differentially experienced across occupational groups, reinforcing broader inequalities in authority, security, and voice within contemporary organizations.

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Appendix F – Faculty vs. Staff: A Bayesian Comparison

Table 4 shows that staff consistently report higher satisfaction and perceived support from staff than faculty, a pattern evident across multiple measures: VAR4 (overall work environment), VAR6 (valued by the institution), VAR9 –VAR13 (voice, opportunities to share concerns, and respect from senior administrators), and VAR19 (communication effectiveness), all of which have strong Bayes evidence. This aligns with organizational sociology theories emphasizing that role position and expectations shape experiences within institutions (Pfeffer & Salancik 1978). Faculty may face higher role strain due to competing teaching, research, and service obligations (Katz & Kahn, 1978).

The discrepancy between faculty and staff also reflects expectation-reality gaps: faculty expectations for administrative responsiveness and recognition are higher. In this regard, their unmet expectations translate into lower satisfaction (Pfeffer 1991). Staff, occupying roles with more clearly defined tasks and direct support, experience immediate recognition and procedural fairness, which enhances their morale (Colquitt et al. 2001).

Measures related to respect and recognition (VAR11–VAR13) suggest that faculty feel less acknowledged by senior administrators, while staff perceive higher levels of respect and support. This finding is consistent with social stratification within organizations (DiMaggio & Powell, 1983). The differential satisfaction across workload and resource-related items (VAR16 – VAR17, VAR36) indicates that material and symbolic rewards interact with institutional position to shape morale (Bolino & Turnley 2005; Fuller et al. 2006).

Finally, VAR28, which measures perceived care from the leadership team, shows that staff rated this higher than faculty. This finding highlights the importance of perceived legitimacy and relational embeddedness in administrative structures (Chatman & O'Reilly 2016). Collectively, these results depict a dual organizational culture in which staff experience the institution as supportive and faculty experience it as bureaucratically constrained. This is consistent with the argument emphasizing the stratified nature of satisfaction and organizational perception in higher education institutions (Fuller et al. 2006).

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Table 4: Means for Faculty vs Staff with Bayesian Evidence

Variable	Faculty	Staff	Bayes Factor	Evidence
VAR3	3.327	3.824	2.565830e+02	*** Strong
VAR4	2.391	3.26	1.392528e+06	*** Strong
VAR5	4.155	4.084	1.610000e-01	Evidence for Null
VAR6	2.545	2.954	5.908000e+00	** Moderate
VAR7	4.104	4.148	1.540000e-01	Evidence for Null
VAR8	2.961	3.139	3.630000e-01	Inconclusive
VAR9	2.716	3.321	4.644310e+02	*** Strong
VAR10	2.918	3.359	1.145500e+01	*** Strong
VAR11	2.324	3.443	5.862759e+08	*** Strong
VAR12	3.064	3.588	4.189300e+01	*** Strong
VAR13	2.891	3.446	2.864720e+02	*** Strong
VAR14	3.9	4.031	2.380000e-01	Evidence for Null
VAR15	3.473	3.71	4.830000e-01	Inconclusive
VAR16	2.881	3.244	1.798000e+00	* Anecdotal
VAR17	2.482	2.977	3.093500e+01	*** Strong

VAR18	3.836	3.412	4.536000e+00	** Moderate
VAR19	2.1	2.794	9.632067e+04	*** Strong
VAR26	2.009	3.124	4.135554e+11	*** Strong
VAR27	2.682	3.323	3.421550e+03	*** Strong
VAR28	1.964	2.649	9.221194e+03	*** Strong
VAR29	2.464	2.458	1.420000e-01	Evidence for Null
VAR30	3.845	4.267	1.346100e+01	*** Strong
VAR31	3.745	4.267	1.563620e+02	*** Strong
VAR32	4.073	3.822	6.430000e-01	Inconclusive
VAR33	4.482	4.277	5.940000e-01	Inconclusive
VAR34	4.1	3.771	1.685000e+00	* Anecdotal
VAR35	3.855	4.084	5.420000e-01	Inconclusive
VAR36	3.864	3.832	1.450000e-01	Evidence for Null
VAR37	3.382	3.145	4.470000e-01	Inconclusive
VAR38	3.759	3.388	3.962000e+00	** Moderate

Appendix G – Codebook

Variable	Question	# Categories	Response options (ordered)	Missing (n)
VAR1	Which of the following best describes your role at the institution?	2	Staff, Faculty	8
VAR2	How many years have you been employed at Utica University?	6	11 - 15 years, 16 - 20 years, More than 20 years, 1 - 4 years, 5 - 10 years, Less than one year	5
VAR3	How would you characterize Utica University for faculty and staff?	5	Almost never welcoming, Rarely welcoming, Sometimes welcoming, Often welcoming, Almost always welcoming	2
VAR4	How satisfied are you with the overall work environment at Utica University?	5	Very dissatisfied, Dissatisfied, Neither satisfied nor dissatisfied, Satisfied, Very satisfied	3
VAR5	How well do you feel your contributions are valued by your department?	5	Not valued at all, Not valued, Neutral, Valued, Highly valued	3
VAR6	How well do you feel your contributions are valued by the institution?	5	Not valued at all, Not valued, Neutral, Valued, Highly valued	3
VAR7	Other than financial, how would you rate the level of support you receive from your department?	5	Poor, Fair, Good, Excellent, Vey poor	3
VAR8	Other than financial, how would you rate the level of support you receive from the institution?	5	Poor, Fair, Good, Excellent, Vey poor	3
VAR9	To what extent do you agree with the following statements? • The institution encourages you to have a voice and express concerns openly.	5	Strongly disagree, Disagree, Neither agree nor disagree, Agree, Strongly agree	4

VAR10	To what extent do you agree with the following statements? • The institution provides you with opportunities to share thoughts and feelings about issues of concern.	5	Strongly disagree, Disagree, Neither agree nor disagree, Agree, Strongly agree	3
VAR11	To what extent do you agree with the following statements? • I feel respected by the University President.	5	Strongly disagree, Disagree, Neither agree nor disagree, Agree, Strongly agree	5
VAR12	To what extent do you agree with the following statements? • I feel respected by the University Provost.	5	Strongly disagree, Disagree, Neither agree nor disagree, Agree, Strongly agree	3
VAR13	To what extent do you agree with the following statements? • I feel respected by other senior administrators.	5	Strongly disagree, Disagree, Neither agree nor disagree, Agree, Strongly agree	4
VAR14	To what extent do you agree with the following statements? • I feel respected by my colleagues.	5	Strongly disagree, Disagree, Neither agree nor disagree, Agree, Strongly agree	3
VAR15	To what extent do you agree with the following statements? • My work responsibilities are clearly defined.	5	Strongly disagree, Disagree, Neither agree nor disagree, Agree, Strongly agree	3
VAR16	To what extent do you agree with the following statements? • My workload is manageable.	5	Strongly disagree, Disagree, Neither agree nor disagree, Agree, Strongly agree	4
VAR17	To what extent do you agree with the following statements? • I have the resources needed to do my job effectively.	5	Strongly disagree, Disagree, Neither agree nor disagree, Agree, Strongly agree	3

VAR18	To what extent do you agree with the following statements? • I often feel stressed or overwhelmed at work.	5	Strongly disagree, Disagree, Neither agree nor disagree, Agree, Strongly agree	3
VAR19	How effective is the institution's communication regarding important updates and changes?	5	Not at all effective, Not so effective, Somewhat effective, Very effective, Extremely effective	3
VAR20	What are your preferred methods of communication? (Check all that apply.) • Global emails	1	Global emails	55
VAR21	What are your preferred methods of communication? (Check all that apply.) • Morning Mention	1	Morning Mention	164
VAR22	What are your preferred methods of communication? (Check all that apply.) • Communications from various affiliate groups (e.g., AAUP, PSAC)	1	Communications from various affiliate groups (e.g., AAUP, PSAC)	148
VAR23	What are your preferred methods of communication? (Check all that apply.) • Discussions with supervisor, department, or school	1	Discussions with supervisor, department, or school	64
VAR24	What are your preferred methods of communication? (Check all that apply.) • 1:1 meeting with a member of the University's senior leadership	1	1:1 meeting with a member of the University's senior leadership	175
VAR25	What are your preferred methods of communication? (Check all that apply.) • Small group discussions with	1	Small group discussions with administrative offices or senior leadership.	127

	administrative offices or senior leadership.			
VAR26	How effective is the University's President when it comes to addressing challenges the institution is facing?	5	Not at all effective, Not so effective, Somewhat effective, Very effective, Extremely effective	5
VAR27	How effective is the University's Provost when it comes to addressing challenges the institution is facing?	5	Not at all effective, Not so effective, Somewhat effective, Very effective, Extremely effective	7
VAR28	To what extent do you feel the University's leadership team cares about your well-being?	5	A great deal, A moderate amount, None at all, A little, A lot	3
VAR29	How satisfied are you with the professional development opportunities available at the institution?	5	Very dissatisfied, Dissatisfied, Neither satisfied nor dissatisfied, Satisfied, Very satisfied	3
VAR30	How much of an impact does each of the following have on your morale? • Salary	5	Not at all, Slight, Some, Much, A great deal	3
VAR31	How much of an impact does each of the following have on your morale? • Benefits	5	Not at all, Slight, Some, Much, A great deal	3
VAR32	How much of an impact does each of the following have on your morale? • Feelings of belonging	5	Not at all, Slight, Some, Much, A great deal	5
VAR33	How much of an impact does each of the following have on your morale? • Feeling valued	5	Not at all, Slight, Some, Much, A great deal	4
VAR34	How much of an impact does each of the following have on your morale? • Workload	5	Not at all, Slight, Some, Much, A great deal	3

VAR35	How much of an impact does each of the following have on your morale? • Staffing levels	5	Not at all, Slight, Some, Much, A great deal	3
VAR36	How much of an impact does each of the following have on your morale? • Resources (e.g., systems, software, departmental budget)	5	Not at all, Slight, Some, Much, A great deal	3
VAR37	How much of an impact does each of the following have on your morale? • Facilities	5	Not at all, Slight, Some, Much, A great deal	3
VAR38	How much of an impact does each of the following have on your morale? • Institutional policies and procedures	5	Not at all, Slight, Some, Much, A great deal	7
VAR39	If you have had any of the concerns identified in Question 14, approximately how long have they affected your morale?	7	3 to 4 years, More than 5 years, 4 to 5 years, 2-3 years, 6 months to 1 year, 1 to 2 years, Less than 6 months	18

Appendix H – Faculty Qualitative Findings

The themes that were initially identified from the faculty responses to the open-ended survey questions included: lack of respect, poor communication, lack of resource, isolation, and senior leadership.

Lack of Respect

No celebration of wins

- Not being recognized for what faculty do, how well they do it, and how much they care is a common concern. Alongside this concern of not being acknowledged for good work is a feeling of being blamed when situations are bad.
- Example quotations (bold emphasis added):
 - “Faculty are never acknowledged for the level of the attention and care that we give the students. The number of faculty who buy food and items for students because the administration either doesn’t care or doesn’t know ... that students’ needs are not being met. So faculty pick up the slack and make up for what the administration is not willing to do. But because of that, admin doesn’t make efforts to actually help the students because they know they can take advantage of faculty because we ALWAYS show up for our students. In ways beyond the classroom. ACKNOLWEDGE THAT.”
 - “Here’s one detail: when [Name] was dean of A&S he asked me for a copy of my book for the office. It was just returned to me because ‘there’s no space’ for faculty publications. Hard to believe the office can’t find a bookshelf to recognize faculty accomplishments. Hard to believe admin things so lowly of us that they can’t show appreciation for is. I don’t believe there’s an administrator on campus who has shown any level of human concern for me in the past year.”
 - “We do a very poor job of meaningful recognition of employees who deserve recognition.”
 - “Quite frankly, it’s awful and I don’t think we can get any lower. In my opinion, it’s been bad since 2020 when we were under-appreciated and undervalued for the extreme personal (not only financial) sacrifices we made during the pandemic that no other local institution went to the same measures that caused their faculty to literally cry late at night prepping for classes while fearing for their lives.”
 - “Before Laura, I felt appreciated for my excellence as a faculty member, and this in turn motivated me to continue doing my best work. I received handwritten notes from the president, provost, and dean applauding the good work I was doing. I still have them! I felt valued for my professional accomplishments, service, and teaching. Since Laura, and the ‘sniff test’ era, I feel that I am actually penalized for striving for excellence—because it usually results in additional work and stress for me, much more than if I just went along with the tide of mediocre performance.”

- Recognizing/celebrating quality work and accomplishments in a personal, genuine way is a common recommendation. Advertising what we do well is another suggestion, as is assisting faculty who strive for excellence.
- Some example quotes are:
 - “Help those faculty who still care to work to create an environment of excellence in all areas of faculty work.”
 - “Be like a parent. Treat the kids with respect, empathy, celebrate their wins, listen to their fears, listen to them complain, but keep the boundaries solid. Be the role model you want your kids to be like.”
 - “Come walk a mile in our shoes. Come see what we do on a day to day basis to teach lectures and organize lab, then tell us to do more with less. Recognize what we mean to this institution and that we are hurting.”
 - “Interact with us more and SHOW you care. Come to see the things we do and take time to share appreciation of those things.”
 - “Provide more ways to publicly recognize/acknowledge employee accomplishments; provide hand-written notes to personally acknowledge people who do good things”
 - “more good news reports; highlight successful programs; invest in successful programs”

Poor relationship among colleagues

- The almost universal feeling of disrespect expressed in the survey was primarily a matter of how upper administration and the Board of Trustees interacts (or do not interact) with faculty. To a lesser extent, there is a feeling of negativity expressed by faculty members concerning interactions with other faculty members and with staff. Feeling disrespected and not valued was common, and there is a widely shared sense that administration has not been fully honest about or apologized for its role in our financial catastrophe.
- Example quotations (bold emphasis added):
 - “Stop treating us like a**holes.”
 - “The Trustees don’t seem to understand what the University is and how best to manage it. While almost every position at the school is essential, the ultimate reason why students go to university is to learn from professors. We are not petulant children.... The whitewashing of previous middle-states reports not only occurred but when faculty brought it up, they were told that the Board didn’t want to hear what we had to say...”
 - “This survey did not ask about the Board of Trustees.... They are so uninformed and over their heads, YET refuse to respect faculty enough to let us help, it is gut wrenching to watch.... The fact that we want to help, and no one cares.”
 - “We are tired, we are disrespected, and our resources are poor – not just salary, but all around – sense of inclusion, sense that our work and expertise are respected...”

- “Buildings get old, but the lack of working blinds in faculty offices, for example, feels more and more like an example of how we are not valued rather than just a sign of aging facilities”
- “I feel disrespected and sometimes bullied by other faculty members who are extremely vocal and do not share my views, or represent my perspective.... While I am very happy with my department (and school) colleagues and culture, I often feel as though there is a hostile work environment when dealing with faculty outside of my school, specifically in A&S, and specifically in Faculty Senate and committee work.”
- “[M]y mind goes to President Pfannestiel’s comments at a spring 2025 meeting that anyone who thinks Utica is closing ‘should just leave.’ That comment spat in the face of faculty like me who have literally been sick with worry wondering about the state of the school, the way I provide for myself and my family. It also disregards the role the current and previous administrators have played in the creation of a climate so filled with uncertainty and fear. There has been extremely little compassion for how being kept in this state of anxiety for YEARS negatively impacts the mental and physical health of Utica University employees, and therefore our ability to do our jobs.”
- There are recommendations for improving this situation, many of which overlap with other concerns expressed in this survey. Some suggestions, like having more events, seem to work against other concerns/suggestions, such as faculty being overworked and underpaid. While events are desired by some, such desires acknowledge that funding is limited.
 - “If there’s going to be a publicly discussed scrutiny of the academic programs, then there should be an equally intensive review of the other areas of campus. And EVERYONE should have a voice.”
 - “The toxic relationship with the board is the most serious problem that MUST be overcome.”
 - “better control in Senate to allow other than the typical 4 who commandeer the meeting every month with their rhetoric which in many instances is not even related to the topic....”
 - “Recognize what retains students is a warm, caring environment in which EVERYONE feels welcome, safe, and respected – including, very importantly, the staff and faculty as well as the students. Staff and faculty do not currently feel – and ARE not – welcome, safe, and respected. Because of this, students can feel it.”
 - “I would also like to see the benefit of our beautiful facilities accessible to us and our families.”
 - “Generalized thanks comes across as insincere and out of touch.”
 - “Demonstrate a genuine interest in the well-being of employees.”
 - “Learn what we actually do.”
 - “Start listening to and working with faculty across ALL disciplines, not just ‘the golden 3’”
 - “Bring us together. Build community. Have events.”

Lack of opportunities to provide valuable input

- This concern touches upon lack of respect as well as poor communication. Transparency, timeliness of communication, and an opportunity for meaningful input seem commonly identified as problems. “Meaningful” input distinguishes between being asked for feedback/advice/committee work and it (a) being used (to some extent, at least) and (b) being insincerely solicited (esp. being ignored). Being told “after the fact” without any opportunity was raised as a problem that seems related to respect in terms of not recognizing that faculty are capable of making meaningful contributions to institutional decisions. Faculty also feel blamed for many institution-wide problems yet, at the same time, powerful to affect them because they are not dealt into decisions. Additionally, there is a sense that when faculty input is solicited, it is not from all faculty but rather from a select few.
- Sample quotes:
 - “It seems like everything is behind closed doors or without any faculty input”
 - “Stop blaming the faculty for the mess the ADMINISTRATION got us in to. We didn’t make these deals, you did. Own it.”
 - “Involve the staff and faculty more in decisions. Feels like no matter what we do we have no control over decisions.”
 - “being transparent and honest answering questions when they arise in a timely manner”
 - “Care about faculty input (other than simple lip-service).”

Poor Communication

Qualitative faculty responses indicate that communication concerns are among the most significant factors affecting morale, trust, and overall confidence in institutional leadership. Respondents consistently describe a communication environment marked by limited transparency, inconsistent messaging, and insufficient opportunities for meaningful dialogue. These issues have contributed to a sense of uncertainty and disconnection across the campus community.

A central theme in the feedback is the perception that major decisions, particularly those involving finances, academic programs, and personnel, are communicated only after they have been finalized. These decisions are, seemingly, often shared without adequate explanation of the rationale behind them. Faculty note that this lack of context makes it difficult to understand the decision-making process or assess how choices align with institutional priorities. Several respondents also described instances in which leadership communicated one message publicly and later reversed course without clarification. This reinforces concerns about inconsistency and reliability.

Many faculty also expressed that communication feels one-directional or performative. Leadership may solicit input through committees, surveys, or consultations, but respondents report rarely seeing evidence that their perspectives influenced outcomes. This has led to a perception that opportunities for engagement are symbolic rather than substantive. It has also diminished trust in

shared governance processes. Additionally, faculty noted that when communication does occur, it can feel abrupt or lacking empathy, particularly during moments of institutional stress. This has amplified the emotional impact of already difficult circumstances.

Timeliness is another recurring concern. Respondents described receiving critical information with little notice, which complicated planning and contributed to a persistent sense of operating in crisis mode. Many faculty reported feeling as though they are continually responding to urgent directives or sudden changes. They described this pattern as unsustainable and detrimental to both morale and productivity. These communication challenges are further compounded by perceived inconsistencies across leadership levels, which leave faculty uncertain about which messages are accurate or authoritative.

Overall, the responses reflect a strong desire for clearer, more consistent, and more transparent communication practices. Faculty emphasized the importance of timely updates, opportunities for genuine engagement, and communication that provides context, acknowledges concerns, and fosters trust. Strengthening communication in these ways is viewed as essential to improving morale and rebuilding confidence in institutional leadership.

Relevant Pull-Quotes from Responses:

- “I am tired of messages from the administration that are simply a fiat with no rationale given.”
- “Clear and timely communication, with a genuine ability to provide input on policies that affect me. No more appointed committees of faculty whose views I don't share and who do not feel obligated to consult with and represent stakeholders.”
- “The lack of communication and transparency from senior leadership, coupled with devastating decisions, has made it quite hard to even show up on a daily basis.”
- “[...] with the prevailing lack of real and sincere communication from the leadership and the lack of transparency - morale has gone to a new low. For the majority of my career here, I truly loved coming to campus. Not anymore. I no longer take pride in this institution. I no longer feel like I am home here.”
- “For quite a while now, when we've been asked to express our concerns & offer input, it seems that all that information goes into a void. There are plenty of examples in the last 10 years where a committee or task force has been convened and done months of work only to have the administration essentially, say "thanks, but we're going a different route". First year seminar and GenEd are two that come to mind. That's demoralizing.”

Lack of Resources

The topic of resources, or the lack thereof, resonates strongly with the faculty at Utica University. This is made evident from the data in the Faculty and Staff Climate survey in which the term resources appears 27 times in the open-ended responses. When responding to the statement, “I have the resources needed to do my job effectively,” only 22.43% of faculty chose either Strongly Agree or Agree while 57.01% of the faculty selected Disagree or Strongly Disagree. In the faculty responses to the open-ended prompts:

- Other Circumstances Impacting Morale (p.10)
- Please share any additional comments regarding the current climate at Utica University (p. 12)

are found numerous responses regarding resources that can be categorized under a wide variety of themes including:

- Insufficient Resources
- “Do More with Less” Culture
- Administrative Disconnect
- Misplaced Accountability
- Inadequate Physical and Technological Infrastructure

According to the qualitative data and emergent themes identified in the comment sections of the Faculty and Staff Climate Survey report, faculty report a pervasive lack of resources, ranging from insufficient classroom supplies to limited opportunities for professional development. Faculty maintain that they are expected to provide a comprehensive education for their students without adequate materials or institutional support. One comment, “we are all being stretched to our limits...asking to do more with less” (p. 14) captures the prevailing sentiment among respondents. In fact, they believe they oftentimes “pick up the slack and make up for what the administration is not willing to do” (p. 22) and yet in the light of this, feel that they are being blamed by the administration for problems that stem directly from these resource deficiencies (p. 35). In fact, comments were made that the administration has also been oblivious to the needs of students that the faculty have also stepped in to ameliorate (p. 22). Despite these efforts, faculty reported that they are expected to “get the job done no matter what” (p. 26).

Both technological and physical infrastructure were described as outdated, unreliable, and inadequate. Examples include “lack of working blinds in faculty offices” (p. 11) and classrooms with “distracting climate control” (p. 36) issues. Faculty noted frustration with management systems not working consistently and noted that it would be appreciated if the administration was “willing to acknowledge it and offer change” (p. 23).

As a result of these persistent limitations, faculty feel “constrained in pursuing continuing education, research, and teaching innovation” (p. 20) but also expressed hope that, moving forward, the university, “invest in professional development and teaching resources” (p. 33) to support the faculty in delivering a high-quality education to their students as this will help to restore moral amongst the faculty.

Isolation

Lack of Collaboration

- What respondents identified
 - Limited collaboration across departments and roles
 - Lack of structured mentorship and onboarding for new faculty
 - Decreased awareness of who works in which departments

- Perception that the Center for Faculty Excellence is underutilized and primarily functions as technical support rather than a collaborative hub
- Representative comments
 - “I’ve learned long ago that more voices at the table get better solutions.”
 - “The Center for Faculty Excellence is not what it was envisioned to be; it is nothing more than tech support. We should be excited to work with each other, but every time I try to do so, I get overburdened, or my colleagues do, and nothing creative ever seems to happen.”
 - “I don’t even know who works in which department anymore.”
- Suggested solutions
 - Return to the vision of The Center for Faculty Excellence as a space for collaboration, innovation, and shared problem-solving
 - Implement structured mentorship and onboarding for new faculty lasting at least one to two semesters
 - Provide small stipends or supported time (e.g., lunch-based faculty learning groups) to encourage collaborative teaching and curriculum development
 - Actively involve faculty in identifying and co-creating solutions

Not understanding the lengths people go to for student support.

- What respondents identified
 - Faculty consistently provide extensive student support beyond formal teaching responsibilities
 - Many faculty contribute personal time and resources to meet student needs
 - A perceived lack of recognition or institutional acknowledgment of these efforts
- Representative comments
 - “Faculty are never acknowledged for the level of attention and care we give to our students.”
 - “A number of faculty buy food or items for our students; administration is not meeting student needs.”
 - “Faculty always show up for students in ways beyond the classroom.”
- Suggested solutions
 - Reduce teaching loads to allow faculty time to provide student support and mentorship
 - Allow faculty to focus more intentionally on improving coursework and student outcomes

Lack of community or opportunities to socialize

- What respondents identified
 - Loss of a sense of institutional community and belonging
 - Few informal opportunities for faculty, staff, and administrators to connect
 - Increased feelings of isolation, loneliness, and emotional disconnection at work
- Representative comments

- “I think we need time to connect with one another outside of formal meetings and surveys.”
- “I no longer feel like I am at home here. I used to feel like I was part of a community that extended across schools. Not anymore.”
- “Now it is a ghost town—no sense of community, no sense of belonging.”
- “It is an isolating and lonely place to work. I can’t count the number of days I come in and no one speaks to me or says a kind word, it’s sad, I hope it changes. I hope someone treats me with respect.”
- Suggested solutions
 - Create informal social opportunities (e.g., coffee groups, shared lunches, low-stakes gatherings)
 - Provide mediation support to help departments work through conflicts and improve relationships
 - Offer venues and events that enhance collegiality across faculty, staff, administration, and students
 - Reintroduce community-building traditions (e.g., themed days, outdoor games, wellness activities with students, bring back squirrel day, or find the hidden moose.)
 - Establish a Care Response Support Team, potentially led by psychology and/or health-related faculty, to support employee well-being

Summary

Respondents emphasized a strong need for leadership to demonstrate genuine, sustained interest in the well-being of employees, not only through policies, but through time, recognition, and opportunities for meaningful connection. Acknowledge and value invisible labor related to student care and well-being

Senior Leadership

Faculty responses about UU Leadership fell into several major themes. It must be noted that some empathized with the challenges of steering an institution through difficult circumstances and praised the president and provost for their efforts. Far more frequently, however, responses linked failures in leadership to low morale.

The subject of inadequate communication figured prominently in these remarks, particularly with regard to a lack of transparency and lack of substantive information. Responses also cited narrow and exclusionary pathways along which communication does occur; that is, between Leadership and select faculty members while ostracizing the views of faculty at large. Faculty also remarked that when feedback from the faculty as a whole has been invited and when committees have been formed to provide input, these responses have often been ignored, which not only proves to waste faculty time but dismisses valuable ideas. “Our administration, including the Board of Trustees,” a respondent wrote, “has been sidelining constituent groups for a long time. They appear to cherry pick the voices they want to listen to and promote that as if every group has had the opportunity to provide input.”

Responses also reflected on the quality of administrators and the Board of Trustees, citing mismanagement, incompetence, and lack of accountability. One respondent remarked that UU “feels like a poorly run business,” rather than a university.” Several remarked that the administration suffers from hiring and promoting from within and urged the incorporation of new perspectives and leaders who possess needed skills. As well, several responses spoke of Leadership making decisions without adequate explanation or apparent logic. Some addressed a negative pattern over time: “We have lost a lot of good staff and faculty due to the same cycle of try, fail, or miss the targeted goal and repeat.”

Another common theme concerned a lack of understanding of the work faculty do to support students, in and out of the classroom. “My workload is unmanageable and it feels as though no matter how hard we try to explain to the administration, our needs” a respondent shared, “we are pushed to do more with less. I am drowning and there is no end in sight.” A number of faculty expressed frustration that Leadership fails to understand the real relationship between faculty and students and the lengths faculty go to to support their students.

Most of the suggested solutions addressing Leadership trace back, in one way or another, to calls for better management skills among the Board of Trustees and Senior Leadership, and the fostering of substantive communication, transparency concerning circumstances and decisions, and respect for both the work faculty do and the value of their perspectives.

Appendix I – Staff Qualitative Findings

The themes that were initially identified from the staff responses to the open-ended survey questions included: communication, poor management/leadership, financial instability, the campus community being divided, siloed, and inequitable, lack of support for students, feeling devalued, understaffed/high workload, and some positive comments.

Communication

Respondents frequently noted issues with communication across domains of constituent groups being communicated with, including between departments, out to the public, from the top down, and to students. Across all of these domains, there was repeated identification of what made the communication poor: respondents felt that the administration has not been transparent with planning, and their communications can come off as insincere with a lack of active listening. Within these comments about poor communication, there was a clear and consistent concern for the lack of an overall strategic plan for the university's financial crisis.

One example that was repeatedly brought up was that staff were confused that campus facilities, such as the athletic facility, could be used. Another example of the lack of transparency in communication about planning related to complaints made about athletics being prioritized when it comes to resources—as respondents claim athletic fields seem to receive more maintenance than other areas of campus. Examples were also brought up about heating and air conditioning not working with no clarification about when these issues might be fixed.

The following are representative comments concerning communication from the survey results:

“... I feel that the University does not share relevant information to faculty, staff and students that impact the day to day climate... We also lack a vision, clear mission and steps/plan to reach our goals.”

“Words and actions at the University need stronger alignment. For example, staff from Career Readiness were furloughed in 2024 to support financial recovery, yet the 2025 Re-Envisioning Utica plan highlights career readiness as a strategic priority. This contradiction gave the impression of either limited strategic planning or a lack of consistency in decision-making. Regardless of intent, it had a noticeable impact on staff morale and confidence in leadership. Greater transparency and coherence between stated goals and operational actions would help restore trust and engagement among employees.”

“there's little to no communication about what's going on or why we're in this mess.”

Suggested Solutions

Respondents offered several types of suggestions that could help improve communication and increase transparency. These included that decision makers should take accountability when communicating, look and sound confident in decisions, align words with actions, be present and engaged, invite all stakeholders to the table, and listen and compromise when possible. Additional suggestions are to have continual climate check-ins, improve communication across departments,

encourage always “selling” UU, provide more notice before important meetings, and ensure these meetings are more widely communicated.

Poor Management/Leadership

Respondents identified many issues related to poor management and leadership. Comments indicated concerns that management was inefficient and showed lack of planning and action. Several were concerned that the administration did not seem to take responsibility and accountability for problems at the university. Respondents also described a lack of organization with management, including a lack of written policies or procedures, no clear onboarding process for new employees, and no repercussions for staff that are not “pulling their weight.” Several respondents commented about a lack of opportunities for advancement and professional development. There were also complaints about high workloads and lack of community-building events.

The following are representative comments from the survey:

“I feel that the University does not share relevant information to faculty, staff and students that impact the day to day climate. We also lack a vision, clear mission and steps/plan to reach our goals. The IEP was good in theory but I don't feel like anyone other than senior leadership had a part in the IEP or the execution of seeing things accomplished.”

“Senior leadership responds to critiques or frustrations in a way that comes across as defensive.”

“My department has extreme issues with staff that are and act racist, sexist, transphobic and overall bigoted and the institution has shown decreasing interest in support. The institution has also seemed to lose opportunities for advancement and in discussion of my department, they have specified there is no positions above entry level and the few positions at and above living wage are being held and guarded by problematic individuals who intend to stay into retirement [...] There is an increasing sense of hostility tied to an understanding that there is no room for growth or raises, forcing good employees out and I know in my department, it has grown a problematic bubble where bigotted individuals stay and anyone well meaning is pressed out.”

“Decisions are seemingly made in vacuums, where the players you would expect to be making decisions are somehow left out - I feel some people are letting power go to their heads... mysteriousness only worsens the silo effect (seriously, why is it so divided when we have a small campus and limited resources?!) and feelings of being devalued.”

Suggested Solutions

Respondents made several suggestions for improvement. These included taking action by making a plan for longevity with concrete solutions, and taking accountability by making an honest statement about the impact of past decisions. Suggestions were made for management to address underperforming workers, including to evaluate and assess supervisors, and ensure a system based on meritocracy versus nepotism. Respondents thought that the administration could offer

more: incentives or rewards for quality work, opportunities for career growth, opportunities for professional development, and opportunities to meet with leadership. Some respondents suggested that the administration investigate incidences of prejudice and intolerance and address negative people. There were suggestions that leadership and management could spend a day in each office and develop better and more thorough employee onboarding procedures.

Financial Instability

Respondents frequently identified issues related to the institution's financial instability as decreasing morale and increasing stress. Respondents described how cuts to salaries, lack of raises and benefits, forced furloughs, and worries about job security have "demoralized" employees and made it "hard to stay motivated to work hard when there is no incentive." Respondents acknowledged that the salary and budget cuts affect employees and departments unequally, and respondents were frustrated by perceived pay inequality and discrepancies between department/office budget constraints. These concerns connect to the previous section on communication as respondents described the negative impacts caused by a lack of transparency and clear communication about financial decisions. For example, respondents described pay inequality, discrepancies between department/office budgets, confusion about the rationale behind some financial decisions, frustrations with budget constraints, and perceptions of frivolous spending. Numerous respondents identified the importance of retaining flex time as one of the only incentives that remains, and, correspondingly, the suggestion to eliminate flex time was described as decreasing morale, increasing stress, and disrespecting the sacrifices staff have already made.

The following are representative comments about the relationship between financial instability and employee morale:

"The ongoing uncertainty of the University's financial stability has been consistently unsettling."

"The feelings of not knowing what might be next are making it hard to see myself in this position long term."

"I think it is fair to conclude that being in a better financial position will help immensely but that is not something that happens overnight. Cuts and freezes over the years have been chipping away at morale leaving people on edge and strapped for resources. And, unfortunately, negativity breeds negativity."

"Some departments have been extremely disciplined in cost control, holding the line on positions and trying to figure out how to do more with less. In other departments, as soon as an opening arises, the position ends up being posted. It sends mixed messages across campus and makes other departments not feel as valued."

"I do feel those making under \$20.00 [an hour] feel a greater impact than most. If possible, it would have meant a lot if the furlough could possibly have been waived for them"

“To have your retirement continuously be taken away as a staff member is very discouraging. Retirement contributions by the University help to offset the extremely low salaries. If flex time is also taken away it will be very detrimental to my family obligations and also help to offset the low salary, furlough, and retirement contributions.”

Suggested Solutions

Respondents suggested that “improv[ing] financial footing” would help improve morale on campus and offered a range of possible solutions, some focused on possible cost saving measures, others on changes that might increase morale. In general, more transparency on budget decisions and communication of a clear timeline for improvement of the financial situation were repeated throughout the feedback. Possible cost saving measures suggestions included: cutting faculty, cutting programs, making cuts more equal between staff and faculty, saving money in other ways (i.e., printing Tangerine in black and white, changing shipping contractors), redistributing resources to areas of strength, reviewing high-salary positions held long term. Respondents named the following ways to improve morale: bring back TIAA, offer better pay and benefits, discontinue the loss of vacation not used by May 31, offer merit-based compensation and/or performance bonuses, offer an option for lower deductible insurance, salary increases, seek course for restoration of pay and retirement benefits, and stop cutting salaries.

Divided, Siloed, and Inequitable

Respondents of the survey frequently reported feeling divided, siloed, and subject to inequitable treatment. This trend presented itself as: a lack of cooperation between departments, lack of voice or representation at higher levels, faculty entitlement and faculty looking down on staff, disparity between union and non-union employees specifically in regards to the ability to speak up, and lastly in terms of facilities and maintenance, respondents felt there was the appearance that athletic venues and grounds are prioritized over other areas of campus.

The following are representative comments about the relationship between feelings of being divided, siloed, and as if there is inequitable treatment that affects employee morale:

“campus has become an ‘us vs them’...faculty vs staff, Administration vs Faculty/staff.”

“We are at war with each other on campus and that isn't healthy.”

“The lack of professionalism and collegiality of the faculty needs to be addressed. Staff have been challenged about FlexTime but the amount of closed faculty doors during non-teaching hours is infuriating. For staff, this is our primary occupation. For faculty this is one income stream and, in some cases, secondary income streams have taken priority. Emails go unanswered, students feel ignored. Out of frustration students turn to staff and we must intervene, sometimes never getting a response from faculty at all. Policy and procedures are ignored. Changes are implemented without any consultation to see if those changes can be supported. There have been actions taken by faculty in an attempt to get the attention of the administration that ultimately made staff feel utterly embarrassed and used.”

“I feel the campus never regained the atmosphere it had pre-covid. Previously it seemed there were more campus events and activities during the day that employees could see or even join in. Petting zoos, Squirrel Day, the chem dept making liquid nitrogen ice cream, telescopes for an eclipse. It made me so glad to work at a college instead of a corporation. No one seems to be having fun anymore; it doesn't feel like a community and much more like any office job. Staff doesn't get to interact with other staff or students outside of emails and meetings.”

“It seems departments work in silos and don't interact outside of their area.”

“There is a huge problem with the way that faculty members treat staff members. Faculty members often talk to staff members as if staff are below the faculty and that the staff members work for them”

“It is very disheartening that it feels like the staff is continually asked to give because the faculty has a union behind them.”

“When I first started here over 11 years ago, I felt like I walked into a family. Since then, things have changed and now I feel like departments are divided. I'm not sure how to change this going forward, but love to get that feeling back on campus again.”

“The sports fields are getting too much care given to them, the rest of the university is floundering in appearance and maintenance”

“Faculty entitlement is another problem. They don't appreciate their privilege. They need to be part of the solution.”

Suggested Solutions

There were a variety of suggested solutions to address feelings of being divided, siloed, and perceived inequitable treatment. The first suggestion was to improve communication. This could be done by: creating more opportunities to meet with leadership, providing gatherings/forums for cross department/cross faculty and staff communication/support, increasing opportunities to collaborate across departments, communicating to faculty and staff together not separately, creating an open forum for staff to speak up, working across departments on goals and action steps leaders want to see, and outlining staff role/mission in IEP.

Another common suggestion was to increase staff and faculty interaction in work and non-work environments. This could be done through social events for faculty and staff to interact together, including monthly happy hours, staff hockey games, and on campus professional development days. Additional ideas consisted of team building activities, such as school spirit Friday's, expanding the “Kudos” program, creating human interest stories for social media, creating a Faculty & Staff “Hall of fame”, hosting community service activities, and conducting focus groups to share ideas.

Other frequent suggestions included to allow staff flexibility to participate in campus events (i.e. orientation picnic, Convocation, Unity Walk, Commencement), including closing offices to allow

staff to participate, to recognize staff efforts, such as staff highlights on new projects, and to promote physical health and wellness by allowing staff and faculty access to athletic facilities in the summer and allowing family access to athletic facilities for recreational use.

Lack of Support for Students

Some respondents commented on the lack of support for students from faculty, staff, and administration. While this area didn't include as many comments as the others, the comments made still seem significant as they allude to direct impacts on student experience. These comments also overlap with the other identified areas, such as having qualified staff as well as the tensions between faculty and staff. Some commented specifically about how there weren't enough classes offered.

The following are representative comments about the relationship between lack of support for students and employee morale:

"I don't think the negativity should spill over to students and their experiences."

"Right now, I feel like I'm funneling students into the same handful of subjects/classes, which sets the already underenrolled programs up for failure."

"Our students should not have to worry about or be affected by staff/faculty cuts." - [staff member saying that a faculty member was sharing they were worried about their job in class in front of students.]

"We need more qualified staff to support the technical infrastructure of the campus and meet the demands of the offices crucial to the institution"

"I often feel effort exerted by various faculty/staff is not comparable where we have certain community members who do an excellent job whereas others show little or no urgency to help a student when asked."

Suggested Solutions

The solutions offered in this category were centered on the need to improve morale and communication; they included:

"Provide gatherings/forums for cross department/cross faculty & staff communication/support."

"More classes for gen-ed."

"I hope that we can all get back to the center of why we are here and be creative in our thinking and work to make this experience positive for all of our students."

"Address faculty and staff who do not contribute positively to the campus environment."

"Accept the demographics of what this institution is and the students that choose to attend here, commit to it, then build the support(s) to meet their needs"

Feeling Devalued

Survey results showed that staff feel unrecognized, underappreciated, and feel disrespected. Other respondents shared that bigotry and prejudice exist within our campus community. Lastly, as it relates to the theme of feeling devalued, some survey respondents noted they feel like they can't speak their mind without the fear of retaliation.

Examples of statements to support that show impacts of feeling devalued on morale include:

"I think its tough being in a department that is going above and beyond what is being asked of them and all we get back is 'you're doing a great job.' we need more than that and if that is all that can be given right now so be it, but departments (as a whole) not pulling their weight or doing what they need to do needs to be more firmly addressed and I think it's everyone's business what is being told to each department"

"Incorrectly referring to the 'Professional Staff Advisory Committee' (Council) in an email regarding morale is more than slightly ironic, and the perceived lack of recognition is precisely a core issue."

"My department has extreme issues with staff that are and act racist, sexist, transphobic and overall bigoted and the institution has shown decreasing interest in support."

"People can say they value you, but where is the action behind this? Decisions are seemingly made in vacuums, where the players you would expect to be making decisions are somehow left out"

"While there are "opportunities" for us to speak at forums or financial town halls, it does not feel safe to do so. ...I am not as open or direct as I could be because I fear professional repercussions for speaking out."

Suggested Solutions

Respondents offered several types of suggestions that could help improve the culture of feeling devalued. These include addressing phobic people including the investigation of incidences of prejudice and intolerance, highlighting the positives, and more overt appreciation. Other suggestions were to bring employees to the table when making decisions and gather input on ways to improve or problem solve. Additionally, creating a safe place to share concerns was mentioned among respondents. Comments about equity between faculty and staff were shared, including ensuring staff feel needed and safe. Lastly, encouraging the use of Personal Time Off (PTO) and having more time off in general were also suggestions to improve the culture of feeling devalued.

Understaffed/High Workload

Respondents often noted departments being understaffed and feelings of having a high workload as impacting their morale. It was noted that staffing shortages often seem to be a result of not being able to fill positions when individuals leave, which contributed strongly to decreased morale. Multiple respondents expressed instances of having to take on additional work, going beyond their

job description, as their teams are getting smaller and demands on their outputs are increasing. Additionally, respondents expressed feeling underappreciated and as if their efforts to take on more work and try to help where they can go unrecognized, either through compensation or from leadership. Practices such as lack of clear onboarding processes and lack of written policies and procedures were also noted as contributing to low morale. Finally, respondents expressed that many of these factors culminate in feelings of stress and burnout, which are highly impacting morale at the University.

The following are representative comments from the survey that show these feelings on being understaffed and having a high workload:

“Not filling positions when people exit and instead moving their work to other employees, allowing teams to shrink smaller and smaller but with the same or increased demands for output, are a large part in the problem of low morale.”

“The staff shortage and salary positions not being filled has forced the majority of my department to do work well exceeding actual job description, for less pay and respect than the supervisor positions”

“Leadership says we are overstaffed, but I beg to differ. Most offices could use way more help/hands on deck for the amount of traffic they see. Other than from my own department, I never really feel like the University cares about the work I do, and it's upsetting.”

“If people go out or leave there is no historical knowledge/skill transfer, or appropriate coverage.”

“This a ‘give more than your all’ attitude that results in a lot of wonderful generosity but also intense burnout and resentment.”

Suggested Solutions

Respondents offered some suggestions for how understaffing and high workloads can be addressed. Some suggestions were for how to improve morale in the short-term, while short-staffing and feelings of high-workload persist. These included ensuring staff can use PTO and flex time and encouraging its use. This will ideally help alleviate some feelings of stress and burnout, in addition to addressing the culture of feeling devalued mentioned in the previous section. However, the main suggestion was to address the short-staffing issues the university is facing. Suggestions for this included to stop cutting positions and combining jobs, to fill positions when people do leave, and to hire more qualified staff.

Positive Comments

Some respondents had positive responses to share, even if these comments were frequently contextualized within other critiques. Only a few comments reflected a purely positive sentiment. In this category, respondents noted that there is a strong sense of community here or that in spite of challenges, they wanted to remain at this institution due to the students and/or relationships with

co-workers. There was acknowledgement that administration has a tough job to do, but maintained hope that they are up to the challenge.

Representative comments from the survey reflecting positive feelings include:

“There is a strong feeling of closeness among the faculty and staff I work with. It feels like a family.”

“Climate is not great. However, staff and faculty are wonderful to each other and I feel a good sense of belonging.”

“I give credit to the leadership team for guiding us through this, it can't be easy to make the decisions that affect so many. I don't know how to change others feelings but I will continue to stay positive and keep perspective.”

“I love what I do, and I love working here. I remain optimistic that things will improve! I think that there are a lot of people working here that feel the same way...that they are here because they love this place! Leadership has a hard job to do but I think they can do it”

“Love it here so far, very welcoming!”

Appendix J – Qualitative Recommendations Summary

Faculty and staff were also asked to provide ideas for how the institution’s leadership team might improve morale at Utica University. The following are ideas respondents contributed. They are organized according to the themes listed above.

Poor Communication

- Make clear the University's Strategic Plan
- Take responsibility when communicating, look and sound confident in decisions, and be present and engaged
- Align words with actions
- Achieve greater transparency and coherence between stated goals and operational actions
- Create an open forum where staff and faculty can speak up
- Invite more stakeholders to the table
- Institute regular campus climate check-ins
- Provide more advanced notice before important meetings and widely communicate information about these events
- Encourage everyone to always be “selling” UU

Lack of Respect & Feeling Devalued

- Address facility issues in a timely manner for all departments
 - Heating and air conditioning should work and when they don’t there should be a clear timeline for when the repairs will be completed
 - Office waste baskets should be emptied, and floors should be vacuumed and mopped regularly
- Address faculty and staff that do not contribute positively
- Investigate instances of prejudice and intolerance and hold individuals accountable for their actions
- Recognize staff and faculty efforts
 - Highlight staff and faculty accomplishments on social media and across school communications
 - Staff and faculty “Hall of Fame”
 - Expand and make more visible the “Kudos” program
- Encourage use of PTO and have more time off in general
- Bring employees to the table when making decisions and gather input on ways to improve or problem solve
- Create a safe place to share concerns

Issues with Leadership & Management

- Take responsibility for past decisions

- Written policies and procedures that can be relied upon to clearly guide expectations and behavior pertaining to:
 - Evaluation of supervisors
 - Onboarding processes for faculty and staff
 - Advancement of staff positions
- Create more opportunities for professional development on campus
- Create more opportunities to meet with leadership
- Investigate instances of prejudice and intolerance and hold these individuals accountable for their actions

Isolated/Divided/Disconnect/Siloed/Inequitable

- Create more gatherings, forums, and focus group for cross department communication & support
- Return to the vision of The Center for Faculty Excellence as a space for collaboration, innovation, and shared problem-solving
- Allow departments to close for staff to attend convocation, commencement, Unity walk, and other large events
- Create more social gatherings on and off campus that can include families (i.e. trunk or treat, fitness classes, school spirit Friday, happy hours)
- Promote physical health and wellness
 - Open all athletic facilities year-round for family members/guests of faculty and staff
 - Make clear that locker rooms are available and provide loops for laundry
- Communicate to faculty and staff together
- Create a faculty/staff care team that supports employee wellness
- Provide mediation support to help departments work through conflicts and improve relationships

Financial Instability & Lack of Resources

- Reinstate employer's TIAA contribution
- Increase starting salaries and reinstate raises
- Provide incentives/rewards for quality work, such as performance bonuses
- Maintain Flex-work week
- Discontinue loss of vacation time not used by May 31st/offer unused vacation time payout
- Add a lower deductible insurance option
- Provide clarity on budgeting between departments
- Stop cutting positions/combining jobs and hire more qualified people
- Suggested cost saving measures to address financial instability included:
 - Cutting faculty
 - Cutting programs
 - Making cuts more equal between staff and faculty

- Saving money in other ways (i.e., printing Tangerine in black and white, changing shipping contractors)
- Redistributing resources to areas of strength
- Reviewing high-salary positions held long term